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‘NDA GOVT STRONGLY WORKING TOWARDS YOUTH-LED DEVELOPMENT’

Youth is NDA’s driving force: PM

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Saturday said the NDA government is strongly working towards youth-led development and one of the “defining features of the last 12 years” has been Indian youth’s confidence in pursuing their aspirations.

Modi also said India’s youth are making their mark across various sectors, from science and technology to manufacturing, space, semi-conductors and drones.

The prime minister said it is heartening to see young Indians contributing to areas that will shape the future of the nation and the world.

“The NDA government is one that is strongly working towards youth-led development. One of the defining features of the last 12 years has been the confidence with which



India’s youth have pursued their aspirations,” he said in a post on X. The Modi government has completed 12 years in power.

The prime minister said through initiatives such as Startup India, Digital India, Skill India and Atal Innovation Mission, an ecosys-

“ONE OF THE DEFINING FEATURES OF THE LAST 12 YEARS HAS BEEN THE CONFIDENCE WITH WHICH INDIA’S YOUTH HAVE PURSUED THEIR ASPIRATIONS”

— PM MODI

tem has emerged that encourages innovation, entrepreneurship and enterprise.

“Today, India is among the world’s leading start-up destinations, and many of these success stories are being scripted by our Yuva Shakti and that too from

Continued on P4

Trump to meet PM Modi during G7 Summit in France next week

WASHINGTON: US President Donald Trump will meet Prime Minister Narendra Modi on the sidelines of the G-7 meeting in France on Wednesday, local media reported quoting US officials.

This will be the first meeting between the two leaders since February last year in Washington.

Trump embarks on the visit to France for the G-7 Summit on Monday morning.

The US president is also scheduled to meet with leaders of Egypt, Qatar, UAE and France during his stay in France.

Modi on Saturday left for a week-long visit to France and Slovakia, during which he will attend the G7 Summit and hold discussions with world leaders on a range of bilateral and global issues. Continued on P4

ROUTINE SORTIE ENDS IN TRAGEDY

IAF AN-32 goes down, 5 dead

SIMONTINI BHATTACHARJEE

NEW DELHI: An Indian Air Force (IAF) AN-32 transport aircraft crashed and caught fire at the Air Force Station in Assam’s Jorhat on Saturday morning killing five personnel.

The Air Force confirmed five casualties in the mishap and shared details. The personnel who lost their lives in the crash have been identified as Sqn Ldr Prashant Singh, Flt Lt Shubham Kumar, Sgt Jitendra Sharma, Agniveervayu Khemaram Kumawat and Agniveervayu Danish Alam.

“An IAF An-32 aircraft met with an accident during a routine sortie today at approximately 1000h at Jorhat, Assam. Crash site management and initial enquiries are on at this time. Continued on P4



Security personnel and others stand near damaged remains of a transport aircraft of the IAF that crashed while landing, in Jorhat district

JORHAT AIR CRASH

» The personnel who lost their lives in the crash have been identified as Sqn Ldr Prashant Singh, Flt Lt Shubham Kumar, Sgt Jitendra Sharma, Agniveervayu Khemaram Kumawat and Agniveervayu Danish Alam

» ‘IAF deeply regrets the loss of lives and stands firmly with the bereaved families in this time of grief’

Pre-dawn search at Abhishek’s residence ends with ‘nil’ seizure

OUR CORRESPONDENT

KOLKATA: In a dramatic pre-dawn operation, police from West Midnapore’s Salboni Police Station arrived at Trinamool Congress (TMC) national general secretary Abhishek Banerjee’s Kalighat

residence around 3 am on Saturday in search of his personal assistant, Sumit Roy.

Police claimed Roy, wanted in connection with an alleged financial embezzlement case, was believed to be inside the residence after his last known mobile tower location pointed

there. After waiting outside for nearly three hours, Disaster Management personnel were called in, and locks were broken to gain entry.

The search reportedly began around 6:30 am and continued for nearly 90 minutes, covering

Continued on P4

Centre takes possession of Jaipur Polo Ground in Delhi

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Officials of the Land & Development Office under the Union Housing and Urban Affairs Ministry on Saturday took physical possession of the 15.20-acre Jaipur Polo Ground in the Race Course area of the national capital, officials said.

The development follows a May 20 eviction order under which the L&DO sought possession of the land parcel, citing its need for a “larger public purpose”.

The order, however, offered no details about the intended use of the land.

On June 8, the Delhi High Court asked a district court to decide on a plea by the Indian

Polo Association (IPA) seeking a stay on the eviction notice.

However, the district court declined to grant interim relief against the order.

The IPA termed the eviction “wrongful, arbitrary and contrary to law,” and said it would pursue all available legal remedies to safeguard its rights and interests.

“As the matter is sub judice and ongoing, the Association does not propose to comment further at this stage,” said IPA counsel, Major (Retd) Nirvikar Singh.

The L&DO had also issued eviction orders to the Race Course Club and Gymkhana Club, saying that their premises were needed for a larger

public purpose.

In a relief to Delhi Gymkhana Club members, the Delhi High Court on May 26 took note of the Centre’s submission that it would not take forcible possession of the colonial-era club by June 5 and observed that no interim order was needed at that stage.

Continued on P4

Lt Gen Dhiraj Seth to be next Army Chief

To take charge on June 30

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Lt Gen Dhiraj Seth will be the next Chief of the Army Staff, the defence ministry announced on Saturday.

Lt Gen Seth, currently serving as the Vice Chief of Army, will take charge of the top position on June 30 when the incumbent Gen Upendra Dwivedi retires.

The senior military officer is an alumnus of the National Defence Academy, Khadakwasla, and was commissioned into the Armoured Corps in December 1986.

Over a distinguished military career spanning nearly four decades, he has extensive experience across operational, strategic, capability development and institutional domains.

Lt Gen Seth has commanded at every level in diverse operational environments. His command assignments include an Armoured Regiment in the desert sector, an Armoured Brigade in



Lieutenant General Dhiraj Seth

the Western Theatre, and a counter-insurgency force in Jammu & Kashmir.

As a Lt General, he commanded the Sudarshan Chakra Corps, one of the Indian Army’s premier strike formations.

He subsequently served as General Officer Commanding, Delhi Area, overseeing key national and international military engagements and ceremonial responsibilities.

Following his elevation as an Army Commander, the officer commanded South Western

Continued on P4

Deal day today: US

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

WASHINGTON: US President Donald Trump said on Saturday that a deal to end the war with Iran will be signed on Sunday and the Strait of Hormuz will be “open to all” immediately after that.

“The Deal is scheduled to get signed tomorrow, and immediately after it is signed, the Hormuz Strait is OPEN TO ALL,” the president said in a post on Truth Social.

Trump also contrasted the proposed agreement with the 2015 nuclear deal negotiated under former president Barack Obama.

“Barack Hussein Obama’s Deal with Iran, the JCPOA, was an easy, beautiful, smooth road to a Nuclear Weapon, which Iran would have had six years ago, and would have used long before now.”

“My Agreement with Iran is the exact opposite, A WALL TO NO NUCLEAR WEAPON! In fact, they no longer want a Nuclear Weapon, nor will they have one, either through purchase, development, or any other form of procurement,” he said.

Trump further claimed that Iran’s nuclear programme had



The Deal is scheduled to get signed today, and immediately after it is signed, the Hormuz Strait is OPEN TO ALL

been effectively neutralised and said the remaining nuclear material would be disposed of at a later stage.

“At the appropriate time, when all is calm, we will go in and get the Nuclear Dust, buried deep under the powerful sunken granite mountains, thanks to our beautiful B-2 Bombers and their brilliant pilots, and downblend and destroy it, whether in Iran, or the United States,” he said.

Pakistan’s Foreign Office earlier said the United States and Iran were in the final stage of negotiations and that an electronic signing ceremony for the agreement was scheduled for Sunday.

India joins elite MISSILE CLUB

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: India has successfully carried out flight-tests of key platforms this week to demonstrate its multi-layered Ballistic Missile Defence system’s power to intercept intercontinental missiles, joining an elite group of nations with this capability.

The BMDs are capable of intercepting incoming long-range nuclear missiles and hostile aircraft including AWACS (airborne warning and control systems). A very few countries including the US, Russia and China are known to have Ballistic Missile Defence (BMD) capabilities. Continued on P4

Veteran TMC leader Manas Bhunia resigns from party

OUR CORRESPONDENT

KOLKATA: TMC, already battling an internal crisis marked by defections and sweeping organisational changes, suffered another major blow on Saturday after veteran leader and former Sabang MLA Manas Ranjan Bhunia resigned from the party’s

Continued on P4

LIKELY TO LEAD BREAKAWAY BLOC

Sudip Banerjee joins TMC’s rebel camp after Shah meeting

OUR CORRESPONDENT

KOLKATA: The suspense surrounding the identity of the Trinamool Congress’ elusive 20th rebel MP appears to have finally ended, with veteran parliamentarian Sudip Banerjee joining the dissident camp in Delhi.

His entry to the TMC’s rebel camp has sent ripples through Bengal’s political circles, as the seasoned leader is now being seen as a potential key figure in shaping—and possibly leading—the breakaway bloc’s future course.

Soon after arriving in Delhi and

Continued on P4

Jaishankar raises Indian mariners’ killing with Rubio

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar on Saturday raised with US Secretary of State Marco Rubio the killing of three Indian mariners in a US military strike in the Gulf of Oman even as Washington firmly asserted that violations of its regional naval blockade will not be tolerated.

Following his phone conversation with Rubio, the external affairs minister described the “lethal” actions by the US military against commercial shipping as unjustified. SeeP5

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‘No energy shortage in country, oil & LPG supply situation comfortable’

Puri further asserted that, while fuel prices rose considerably in many countries, rates in India dropped by 3.1% from May 2022 to May 2026

OUR CORRESPONDENT

CHANDIGARH/LUDHIANA: Union Minister Hardeep Singh Puri on Saturday said there is no shortage of energy in the country and the supply situation of crude oil, LPG and natural gas is quite comfortable. Speaking with reporters in Ludhiana, Puri further asserted that, while fuel prices rose considerably in many countries, rates in India dropped by 3.1 per cent from May 2022 to May 2026.

The petroleum and natural gas minister said oil prices rose across the world in the wake of the Iran conflict.

Sharing data of fuel prices during May 2022 to May 2026, Puri said petrol prices in Pakistan rose by 70 per cent, Sri Lanka by 66 per cent, France by 47 per cent, Italy 46 per cent, Bangladesh 36 per cent and the US 35 per cent.

“In India between May 2022 and May 2026, prices dropped by 3.1 per cent. On one hand, prices rose by 70-80 per cent in the world, but here (Prime Minister Narendra) Modi ji reduced prices by 3.1 per cent,” he said.

“How did it happen? The cost of petrol at the extraction point, then add insurance cost, freight, margin, Centre’s excise



Union Petroleum and Natural Gas Minister Hardeep Singh Puri

Sharing data of fuel prices during May 2022 to May 2026, Puri said petrol prices in Pakistan rose by 70%, Sri Lanka by 66%, France by 47%, Italy 46%, Bangladesh 36% and the US 35%

duty and states’ VAT.

Fuel prices dropped after the Prime Minister reduced the central excise duty three times in November 2021, May 2022 and now recently, he pointed out.

“A few weeks ago, excise duty on petrol and diesel was reduced by Rs 10 a litre,” he said, adding that it put an additional

burden of Rs 1 lakh crore on the budget.

But the PM did not want people to face any financial burden, he said.

“When we raised petrol and diesel prices, how much did it increase? Fuel prices rose by Rs 7.60 a litre,” he said. In addition to Japan, there was the lowest

Highlights

» ‘In India between May 2022 and May 2026, prices dropped by 3.1 per cent’

» ‘On one hand, prices rose by 70-80 per cent in the world, but here Prime Minister Narendra Modi reduced prices by 3.1 per cent,’ Puri said

» ‘Fuel prices dropped after PM reduced excise duty three times in Nov 2021, May 2022 & now recently’

» ‘LPG connection holders were being asked to shift to piped gas. We have a maximum stock of LPG which is 75-80 days of stock’

have natural gas stock for over 60 days,” he said.

On the LPG situation, he said it is also quite comfortable.

For example, if 80,000 metric tonne of LPG per day were used, we ourselves used to make 32,000 MT and it has now been raised to 54,000 MT, he said, which led to reduction in dependence on its import.

He further said LPG connection holders were being asked to shift to piped gas. “We have a maximum stock of LPG which is 75-80 days of stock,” he said.

On E85 fuel (85 per cent ethanol blended petrol), he said at present, there are 47 E85 fuel pumps in the NCR.

By December 2026, the strength of pumps would go up to 500 and by December 2027, it would further increase to 5,000 pumps, he said.

To a question on the killing of three Indian seafarers in a US military strike on a merchant vessel in the Gulf of Oman, he said India has lodged a strong protest.

India summoned US Charge d’Affaires twice, while External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar raised it with US Secretary of State Marco Rubio in this regard, he said.

Inflation seen at 5% in FY27, 50-75 bps rate hikes likely, says report

NEW DELHI: Inflation is headed higher to 5.0 per cent in FY27 with core at 4.6 per cent, ICICI Bank Global Markets said, as West Asia conflict and a below-normal monsoon keep upside risks alive. The brokerage now sees a case for policy rates to be hiked by 50-75 bps, with the MPC already acknowledging higher H2 estimates.

“Inflation moved to 16-month high,” ICICI Bank Global Markets noted in its June 12, 2026 report. CPI rose to 3.94 per cent YoY in May from 3.48 per cent in April, slightly below the firm’s 4.05 per cent estimate but still showing broad-based pressure.

Food inflation accelerated to 4.8 per cent YoY from 4.2 per cent in April, core to 3.9 per cent from 3.7 per cent, and energy to 1.9 per cent from 0.4 per cent.

Looking ahead, the brokerage flagged the conflict as a key risk.

“The ongoing uncertainty around the resolution of the conflict could continue to impart an upside-bias to the inflation, with second-round impact of higher input costs seen across household items, appliances and other segments,” ICICI Bank Global Markets said. A below-normal monsoon at -10 per cent of LPA adds another layer: rain-fed crops like coarse cereals, pulses, oilseeds and spices face production risk, while cereals remain better protected due to irrigation and stocks.

Food momentum is already



Food inflation accelerated to 4.8 per cent YoY from 4.2 per cent in April, core to 3.9 per cent from 3.7 per cent & energy to 1.9 per cent from 0.4 per cent

turning. Vegetables inflation jumped to 5.7 per cent YoY in May, highest in 10 months, after five months of contraction.

Tomatoes surged 26 per cent MoM, cauliflower 12 per cent MoM, cabbage 11 per cent MoM and potato 4.5 per cent MoM due to extreme heat.

Eggs rose 2.6 per cent MoM, ready-made products 1.5 per cent MoM, milk and dairy 0.9 per cent MoM, and edible oils 0.8 per cent MoM. On YoY basis, oil and fats and

fresh meat both ran at 9.5 per cent, fruits and nuts 8.2 per cent, fish and seafood 7.5 per cent, and spices and seeds 6.8 per cent.

Core pressure is also firming. “Core inflation excluding jewelry rose to 2.4 per cent YoY from 2.2 per cent YoY given rising prices across restaurant services 5.7 per cent YoY, clothing and footwear 3.0 per cent YoY and household goods and appliances 1.9 per cent YoY,” the brokerage said. Energy inflation picked up as petrol, diesel, LPG, CNG and kerosene prices rose with global crude.

With food prices dependent on monsoon distribution and El Nino risk, plus higher global food prices feeding through, ICICI Bank Global Markets expects inflation to average 5.0 per cent in FY27 versus RBI’s 5.1 per cent. The recent dip in oil prices is a positive, but unless geopolitical risks ease quickly, rate hikes remain on the table. AGENCIES

‘Trust only true currency for insolvency professionals’

NEW DELHI: Corporate Affairs Secretary Deepti Gaur Mukherjee on Saturday emphasised the importance of the code of conduct for insolvency professionals and said their financial intellect will be useless if there is no “ethical anchor”.

“Trust is the only true currency and the Code of Conduct under the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (IBC) is non-negotiable, she said.

The secretary was speaking at the convocation ceremony of 6th Batch of Post Graduate Insolvency Programme (PGIP) and a conference on a decade of insolvency reforms in the national capital.

The course is offered by the Indian Institute of Corporate Affairs (IICA).

“All your financial intellect, your intellect and strategic thinking are completely useless if you don’t have ethical anchor,” Mukherjee said.

According to her, the spirit of IBC is important and the insolvency professionals should never misrepresent facts.

IBC provides a framework for a market-linked and time-bound resolution of stressed assets.

The Code is implemented by the corporate affairs ministry.

Insolvency professionals play a key part in IBC ecosystem. “We cannot outsource our fundamentals duties...,” Mukherjee said and highlighted the need for integrity, objectivity and impartiality. PTI

SEBI moves SC against SAT relief to SICCL officials in OFCD case

NEW DELHI: The Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) has moved the Supreme Court partially challenging a Securities Appellate Tribunal (SAT) order granting relief to four managers and the company secretary of Sahara India Commercial Corporation Ltd (SICCL).

A vacation bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justice V Mohana is scheduled to hear the plea of SEBI on June 18.

On March 9, the SAT upheld regulatory action by the SEBI against SICCL and dismissed appeals filed by the company and its directors in connection with the alleged illegal issuance of optionally fully convertible debentures (OFCDs).

The three-member SAT bench had ruled that the OFCDs issued by SICCL between 1998



and 2008 constituted a public offer, bringing them within SEBI’s regulatory jurisdiction.

The tribunal had said that the SICCL mobilised around Rs 14,106 crore from nearly 1.98 crore investors through these debentures during the period. It also held that such a large-scale mobilisation of funds from such a huge number of investors could not be treated as a private placement, as claimed by the company.

While dismissing the

appeals filed by SICCL and its directors, the tribunal had allowed a separate appeal filed by four managers and the company secretary, while holding that as employees they could not be held liable for the company’s actions. It also noted that the prospectus had been signed by the company secretary pursuant to powers of attorney granted by the directors, who remained responsible as principals for the acts of their agent.

The SEBI has now challenged that part of the ruling before the apex court. The case pertains to an October 2018 order passed by SEBI directing the company to refund the money raised through the debentures, disclose details of its inventory, and debar certain officials from accessing the securities market. AGENCIES

Court orders 5 days ED custody for Gautam Doshi in Reliance ADA money laundering case

NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI: A special court in Delhi has remanded Gautam Bhailal Doshi to five days of Enforcement Directorate (ED) custody in connection with the alleged Rs 40,000-crore bank fraud and money laundering case linked to the Reliance ADA Group.

Custody follows judicial review amid procedural necessity. Details remain under official scrutiny without public clarification.

Special Judge Gaurav Rao of the Rouse Avenue Court held that custodial interrogation was necessary to investigate the alleged diversion, examining how money moved depended on controlled interviews.

Loans given by a group of banks had reportedly been rerouted; understanding that

path required oversight.

Detention allowed scrutiny into where funds flowed, who directed them, and why layers formed. Investigation could proceed only under supervision.

Investigations point to loan amounts taken by firms like Reliance Communications, Reliance Telecom, and Reliance Infratel having moved abroad – via offshore accounts and international transfers – rather than serving approved uses. Such sums, it is claimed, found their way into mutual fund holdings along with internal group ventures.

Some allocations reportedly supported financial instruments instead of core business needs. As findings emerged, attention turned toward cross-border mechanisms enabling the shift. While official purposes were cited initially, alternative

destinations appear to have absorbed significant shares.

According to the Enforcement Directorate, Doshi occupied central roles in finance and management at Reliance ADA Group.

Banking control is said to have extended across 161 accounts tied to 105 companies under the conglomerate.

Oversight included dealings with international funding setups, along with instruments such as foreign currency convertible bonds. Activities also touched external bank holdings and enterprises registered beyond national borders.

The judiciary noted that confrontation between the Enforcement Directorate and the accused – using recovered emails, digital files, and monetary papers – was essential to reveal the breadth of the pur-

ported scheme. Uncovering those who benefited required such evidence.

Tracing assets obtained through suspected illegal earnings, whether within India or beyond its borders, depended on these materials.

Hence, custody was awarded to ED through June 18, since questioning while in detention remained key for examining claims around obtaining, hiding, shifting, and spending illicit funds.

Each day, a state-run hospital must conduct a health check on Doshi. Medical treatment follows official directives without delay. Contact with legal counsel occurs once per twenty-four hours. Family visits are permitted under supervision. Custody conditions include these provisions until further order.

Farm credit demand likely to stay strong in FY27: NABARD

NEW DELHI: Demand for agricultural and rural credit is expected to remain strong in 2026-27, supported by higher input costs, wider Kisan Credit Card (KCC) coverage and increasing investments in allied activities, mechanisation and agricultural infrastructure, according to NABARD Deputy Managing Director Ajay Kumar Sood.

Sood said the demand for farm credit has grown significantly over the past decade and is expected to continue rising, although at a gradual pace.

“Yes, it will definitely improve. We will see some steady improvement. As far as the latest figures are concerned, if I compare these figures since 2014-15, the agricultural credit disbursement was around Rs 8.5 lakh crore. Now, if I compare it with 2025-26, it’s around Rs 30 lakh crore, which too is provisional. So it’s expected to rise further,” Sood said.

On the outlook for the next financial year, he said, “For 2026-27 also, demand will be very resilient, though it may be a more gradual pace of growth. Growth is basically happening because it is driven by higher input costs, enhanced KCC coverage and rising credit absorption in allied activities, mechanisation and agri-infrastructure.” AGENCIES

RBI eyes simpler cross-border payment approvals under Vision 2028: EY report

‘RBI is shifting its focus from expanding digital payment adoption to improving the efficiency of international transactions’

NEW DELHI: The RBI plans to simplify cross-border payment approvals and reduce regulatory hurdles for businesses and exporters as part of its Payments Vision 2028, according to an EY report that identifies cross-border payments as a key priority for the next phase of digital payments growth.

In its report, Payments Vision 2028: Preparing to Shape India’s Payment Frontier, EY said the RBI is shifting its focus

from expanding digital payment adoption to improving the efficiency of international transactions and strengthening India’s role in global payments.

A major proposal under the framework is the possible introduction of a single-window application process for cross-border payment authorisations under both the Payment and Settlement Systems (PSS) Act and the Foreign Exchange Management Act. EY said the

CLOSER LOOK

» A major proposal is to introduce of a single-window application process for cross-border payment approvals

» RBI is increasingly looking to leverage AI to strengthen risk monitoring, fraud detection and policymaking

» Jaishankar had told Wang that once disengagement is completed at all friction points, then the two sides could

RBI also plans a comprehensive review of the cross-border payments ecosystem to eliminate

regulatory and operational bottlenecks, particularly for businesses involved in international

trade and MSME exporters.

“The approach for 2028 is highly structured and efficiency-driven,” the report noted, adding that the measures are aimed at improving ease of doing business and making cross-border transactions more seamless. The report said the new focus marks an evolution from the previous payments vision, which largely centred on the international expansion of domestic payment systems

such as UPI, RuPay, NEFT and RTGS.

Beyond cross-border payments, Payments Vision 2028 places strong emphasis on user protection, fraud management, interoperability and data-driven oversight. According to EY, the RBI is increasingly looking to leverage artificial intelligence and advanced analytics to strengthen risk monitoring, fraud detection and policymaking. The report high-

lighted plans for AI-enabled, queryable payments databases that could enhance supervisory capabilities and improve decision-making.

Overall, EY said the vision aims to position India as a global leader not only in payment volumes but also in payment system design, standards and innovation, while creating a more transparent and efficient ecosystem for businesses and exporters. AGENCIES

Smart LEDs to light up Delhi's roads

Govt clears Rs 473-cr smart lighting project

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: In a major push towards making the city safer, smarter and more energy efficient, the Delhi government has finalised a Rs 473.24-crore project to replace nearly 96,000 conventional streetlights on PWD roads with advanced Smart LED lighting systems equipped with real-time monitoring and centralised control. The ambitious initiative promises to eliminate dark spots, improve women's safety and generate annual energy savings of around Rs.25 crore.

Under the project, all existing High Pressure Sodium Vapour (HPSV) and conventional LED streetlights installed on PWD roads will be replaced with Smart LED lights. The network covers approximately 96,000 streetlights mounted on 51,160 poles, while an additional 5,000 poles will be installed to address existing dark spots, missing poles and future requirements.

The new system will be monitored through a Centralised Command Centre (CCC), enabling authorities to track the status of every individual streetlight in real time. Unlike the current complaint-based maintenance mechanism, faults and non-functional lights will be detected instantly, ensuring quicker rectification and improved service delivery.

The project is expected to significantly reduce electricity consumption, saving nearly 40 million units of power annually and generating energy sav-



The Smart LED system will also provide more uniform illumination PTI

Highlights

- » The project aims to eliminate dark spots, improve women's safety and generate annual energy savings of nearly Rs 25 crore
- » The network will cover around 96,000 streetlights mounted on 51,160 poles

ings of approximately Rs.25 crore every year. Smart LEDs will also offer uniform illumination, improved lux levels, reduced light pollution and better visual comfort for road users. To ensure accountability, the contract includes a seven-year warranty on lighting fixtures and five years of operation and maintenance responsibility with the contractor. The tender also incorporates stringent

service-level agreements with performance-linked incentives and penalties. Payments will follow a deferred model, with 25 per cent released upfront and the remaining 75 per cent paid in instalments over five years.

Highlighting the significance of the initiative, PWD minister Parvesh Sahib Singh said, "Delhi's roads are not merely corridors of transportation; they are vital public spaces that must be safe, well-lit and accessible for every citizen. Our government is committed to creating a modern urban infrastructure that prioritises public safety, technological innovation and energy efficiency." He added: "This is a transformative step towards building a smarter, safer and more energy-efficient Delhi. We are laying the foundation for a city that is better illuminated, better managed and better prepared."

Showers lower mercury but humidity turns up

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A recent spell of rainfall has provided a welcome respite from the extreme heat in the national capital. However, weather experts have warned that Delhiites may experience discomfort due to elevated humidity levels in the coming days.

Delhi on Saturday recorded a maximum temperature of 35.6 degrees Celsius, 4.3 notches below the season's average, the India Meteorological Department (IMD) said.

The minimum temperature was recorded at 21.4 degrees Celsius, 6.6 notches below the season's average. The relative humidity was recorded at 48 per cent at 5.30 pm.

Weather experts said Delhi



Overcast skies loom over the Kartavya Path PTI

is likely to witness another spell of thunderstorms, lightning and rain on Saturday evening and night, similar to the weather activity experienced on Friday night. The conditions are being influenced by a western disturbance that is currently positioned over the hills and is gradually moving away.

As the system weakens and shifts further away, its impact on Delhi is expected to reduce from Sunday onwards.

Consequently, maximum temperatures are expected to begin a gradual rise over the coming days, weather experts said. The IMD has forecast partly cloudy skies with thun-

MCD honours sanitation workers

NEW DELHI: The Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD), through its Karol Bagh Zone, organised a Sanitation Heroes Felicitation Ceremony along with a cultural and awareness programme at MCD Park in New Rajinder Nagar under its Information, Education and Communication (IEC) and Capacity Building initiative.

The programme brought together Resident Welfare Associations (RWAs), non-governmental organisations, sanitation staff and local residents to encourage greater community participation in waste management and cleanliness drives. Representatives from IPCA conducted an awareness session on the latest Solid Waste Management (SWM) rules and explained the role of Aerobins.

Deputy Mayor Pant leads cleanliness drive in Karkardooma

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: Deputy Mayor Dr. Monika Pant on participated in a special cleanliness drive at Karkardooma Village in Delhi's Shahdara South Zone, highlighting the importance of community participation in maintaining sanitation and promoting responsible waste management.

During the visit, Dr. Pant inspected sanitation conditions in the area and interacted with local residents to spread awareness about cleanliness practices. She appealed to citizens to actively contribute towards keeping the capital clean, hygienic and environmentally sustainable.

Emphasising the importance of waste segregation at the household level, the Deputy Mayor urged residents to



separate wet and dry waste and avoid mixing plastic with other categories of waste. She said that proper segregation strengthens waste management systems and reduces environmental burden.

Dr. Pant stated that improving sanitation and encouraging sustainable waste disposal remain key priorities of the Municipal Corporation of Delhi. She added that these

der and lightning for Sunday, and no significant weather warnings have been issued. The minimum temperature is likely to be around 24 degrees Celsius, while the maximum temperature is expected to reach about 37 degrees Celsius.

Despite the absence of any significant heatwave conditions, weather experts said residents are likely to experience discomfort over the next few days due to high humidity levels left behind by the recent spell of rain. The combination of increasing temperatures and moisture in the air is projected to contribute to this discomfort.

Delhi's air quality was recorded in the "satisfactory" category at 6 pm on Saturday, with an Air Quality Index (AQI) reading of 111.

DU's new SWAYAM credit policy sparks debate

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Delhi University's decision to permit students to earn a portion of their academic credits through online learning platforms has triggered a debate over the future of classroom education and the role of digital learning in public universities.

Under a notification issued on June 1 in line with the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020, the University has allowed students to earn up to five per cent of their total programme credits through SWAYAM and other approved online platforms.

According to the policy, students enrolled in four-year undergraduate programmes can earn up to eight credits online, while postgraduate students can obtain up to four credits through such courses. These credits may also be counted towards Value Added Courses (VACs) and Skill Enhancement Courses (SECs). The University administration has defended the move, stating that the proposal received approval from the Academic Council and is intended to expand learning opportunities, encourage interdisciplinary education, and help students acquire additional skills through flexible learning modes.

However, according to PTI, the Academic for Action and Development Teachers Association (AADTA) has opposed the decision, expressing concern over its possible implications for higher education institutions. AADTA described it as the gradual dilution of classroom-based teaching.

Consumers' interests safe with us, claims power minister Sood

NEW DELHI: Addressing concerns regarding the recent Power Purchase Adjustment Cost revision, Power Minister Ashish Sood on Saturday said the Delhi government will ensure consumers remain protected amid a global fuel cost surge.

Sood said that the Power Purchase Adjustment Cost (PPAC) is a statutory mechanism provided under the country's electricity laws and is not a new arrangement.

"The provision enables electricity distribution companies to adjust for fluctuations in fuel and power procurement costs on a monthly basis," Sood said.

According to the minister, the adjustment has become necessary due to an 'unprecedented' rise in global fuel prices triggered by the ongoing West Asia crisis and other international factors.

"The electricity laws of the country already permit power companies to adjust for the rising cost of fuel used to generate electricity. Due to the situation in West Asia and other prevailing circumstances, fuel costs have risen sharply, leading to a 31 per cent increase in power procurement costs during the

Closer Look

- » Sood said that the Power Purchase Adjustment Cost (PPAC) is a statutory mechanism provided under the country's electricity laws and is not a new arrangement
- » According to the minister, the adjustment has become necessary due to an 'unprecedented' rise in global fuel prices

past month," Sood further said. He added that despite this substantial increase in generation costs, timely intervention by the Delhi government ensured that the burden on consumers remained minimal.

"Even though power procurement costs rose by 31 per cent, the Delhi Electricity Regulatory Commission (DERC) has allowed only an average increase of 2.4 per cent in PPAC. Earlier, the PPAC had been capped at 14.5 per cent till March 31," Sood said.

THE DRIVE WILL BEGIN FROM GEETA COLONY CM to lead Yamuna cleanliness drive today

NEW DELHI: Chief Minister Rekha Gupta will lead the 'Maa Yamuna Riverbank Cleanliness Drive' from east Delhi's Geeta Colony on June 14, officials said on Saturday.

The campaign is an important initiative for cleaning riverbanks, increasing public awareness about environmental conservation and transforming public participation into a broad-based people's movement.

"The protection and cleanliness of the Yamuna are not only the responsibility of the government, but also the duty of every citizen. The campaign is being organised with the objective of taking this message to the people and encouraging collective participation," Gupta said in a statement.

The cleanliness of the Yamuna is not a one-day pro-



A general view of the Yamuna River FILE

gramme, but a continuous public movement that requires the participation of every section of society, she said.

According to the statement, Gupta will lead the cleanliness drive at Thokar No. 14, Geeta Colony Ghat. Cabinet ministers and other

dignitaries will also participate in the campaign at different locations, it said.

Delhi Assembly Speaker Vijender Gupta will be present at the Old Railway Bridge and Deputy Speaker Mohan Singh Bisht at Dedh Pusha, Sonia Vihar. Water Minister Parvesh

“The protection and cleanliness of the Yamuna are not only the responsibility of the govt, but also the duty of every citizen”
— Rekha Gupta

Sahib Singh will lead the campaign at Hathi Ghat on the ITO Downstream Western Bank.

Around 500 social, religious, educational and voluntary organisations, along with volunteers and Delhi residents, are expected to participate in the campaign.

Six years on, no trial yet for Umar, Sharjeel; move fresh bail pleas

NEW DELHI: Activists Umar Khalid and Sharjeel Imam have moved fresh bail applications before a court here in the larger conspiracy case related to the 2020 northeast Delhi riots, contending that their continued incarceration without commencement of trial violated their fundamental right to liberty.

Khalid's plea also argued that even as his earlier application was rejected by the apex court, subsequent judicial developments constituted a "change in circumstances". He referred to the court's remarks in May in another case, asserting that "bail is the rule..." even under the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA).

The fresh pleas were filed before the Additional Sessions Judge Sumedh Saini after the Supreme Court on January 5 refused them bail in the case registered under UAPA.

The Delhi court has sought a response from the Delhi Police

on both the plea and listed the matter for hearing on July 4.

In his application, Imam said there had been no "significant development" in the proceedings even six months after the Supreme Court judgment denying him bail and that he had remained in custody for nearly six years.

The plea said charges were yet to be framed in the case despite prolonged incarceration of the accused persons.

Imam's application argued that subsequent judgments of the Supreme Court, including in Syed Iftikhar Andrabi versus NIA and Tasleem Ahmed versus State (Govt of NCT of Delhi), had clarified the legal position regarding grant of bail in cases involving long incarceration under the UAPA. The plea further said Imam was not present in Delhi after the second week of January 2020 and was already in custody in another case before the riots

broke out in northeast Delhi in February that year.

Similarly, Khalid, in his bail plea, has cited prolonged incarceration and delay in trial, submitting that he has spent nearly six years in custody without charges being framed. His application said the trial was unlikely to commence in the near future considering the large number of accused, witnesses and documents relied upon by the prosecution. The plea referred to the apex court's observations in its May 18 order in a terror-related case. While granting bail to the accused, a two-judge bench criticised the January 5 verdict and emphasised that anti-terror laws should not become a tool for indefinite detention. Khalid has argued that subsequent judicial developments constituted a "change in circumstances", making the present bail plea maintainable despite rejection of his earlier application by the Apex court.

Cheers return as beer brands refill shelves

'Sales rise by 10% this May as popular brands regain regain shelf space'

NEW DELHI: Beer sales in Delhi rose by nearly 10 per cent in May this year compared to the same period last year, driven largely by the return of popular national brands to retail shelves, according to officials from the excise department.

Official data showed that sales touched 11,12,761 cases in May 2026, up from 10,10,524 cases sold during the corresponding month last year.

The increase comes amid a sharp rise in the availability and market share of well-known national beer brands, which accounted for 54 per cent of total beer sales this May. In comparison, their share stood at just 24 per cent in May 2025 and 38 per cent in May 2024.

In Short

- » The report presents findings from the first year of a two-year survey exercise that began in January 2025, officials said
- » Under the project, Delhi was divided into grids measuring 6.6 km by 6.6



km, with 145 randomly selected sub-cells covering around 11 per cent of the city's area

national brands contributed 5,96,351 cases to overall beer sales this May, more than double the 2,47,143 cases sold in the same period last year.

At the same time, the share of other brands — including lesser-known labels and imported beers from Nepal

and Bhutan — fell to 46 per cent this year from 62 per cent in May 2024, indicating a shift in consumer preference back towards established domestic brands.

"The beer sales have also seen around a 10 per cent increase this May in comparison to the previous year during the same period," an official document stated.

The data also highlighted that draught beer consumption continues to remain concentrated in restaurants and clubs across the national capital. A total of 1,521 cases of draught beer were sold in May this year. Of these, restaurants accounted for 1,365 cases, clubs for 126 cases, and Delhi State Industrial and Infrastructure Devel-

opment Corporation (DSIIDC) vends for 30 cases.

Excise department officials said they have continued monitoring the market following complaints raised by the industry last year regarding alleged "brand pushing" at retail outlets.

"Last year, there was an issue regarding brand pushing raised by the industry. The excise department has been monitoring the situation. We also conduct surprise inspections to keep a tab," a government official said. Officials added that May and June remain the busiest months for beer sales in Delhi as consumers increasingly opt for chilled beverages to cope with the intense summer heat.

City Briefs

POLICE COMMISSIONER HONOURS PERSONNEL FOR SERVICE

NEW DELHI: Delhi Police Commissioner Satish Golchha on Saturday felicitated police personnel for their outstanding achievements in the line of duty. Constables Angad Singh Meena and Manish Kumar, both posted at Mehrauli Police Station in South District, were granted out-of-turn promotions and elevated to the rank of Head Constable for their role in rescue operations during a building collapse incident on May 30.



TEMPLE TOURISM BUSES TO RUN UNDER NEW SPIRITUAL CIRCUIT

NEW DELHI: Visitors will soon be able to travel from Akshardham to the centuries-old Yogmaya Temple on dedicated tourism buses as the Delhi government plans to launch a spiritual tourism circuit connecting prominent temples across the capital, an official said on Saturday. The Delhi Tourism and Transport Development Corporation is planning to introduce two special buses under the initiative.

'IAF SERVES AS A SOURCE OF INSPIRATION FOR CRORES OF PEOPLE'

Emerging technology has altered definition of warfare, says Rajnath

OUR CORRESPONDENT

HYDERABAD: Asserting that new recruits to the armed forces must be mentally prepared for the evolving nature of modern conflict, Defence minister Rajnath Singh on Saturday said major powers no longer hold an edge on the battlefield as even smaller forces can inflict significant damage using specialised tactics.

Addressing the Combined Graduation Parade (CGP) at the Air Force Academy at Dundigal near here, Singh also said emerging technologies have altered the very definition of warfare.

"Earlier, it seemed that the big powers had a decisive edge on the battlefield. But now, comparatively, even small powers can cause heavy losses with their small but dangerous weapons and new tactics. My purpose in telling you all this is that you should be mentally ready



Defence minister Rajnath Singh reviews the Combined Graduation Parade at the Air Force Academy, Dundigal, in Hyderabad, Telangana, Saturday PTI

for any form of warfare," he said.

"In contrast to the visibility of soldiers and equipment earlier, many systems such as radars, satellites, drones, sensors and robotics are deployed in modern warfare. Such scenarios are being witnessed now in which traffic systems and CCTVs of adversaries are being controlled," he said.

According to him, the definition of warfare has changed to a great extent. The newly commissioned officers should understand modern warfare and strategies and adapt, adopt, and if necessary, amend them.

Underscoring the importance of smart work along with hard work, he said smart nations are carving out a place

for themselves in the modern technology landscape.

Noting that IAF serves as a source of inspiration for crores of Indians, he cited the example of astronaut Shubhanshu Shukla and exhorted the officers to uphold the rich legacy of the Force.

Congratulating the female pilots commissioned by the

Highlights

» Singh said major powers no longer hold an edge on the battlefield as even smaller forces can inflict significant damage using specialised tactics

» Smart nations are carving out a place for themselves in the modern technology landscape, Singh said

Indian Air Force, he said their growing numbers is making the IAF even more powerful, balanced and robust, which demonstrates the strength of the inclusive force.

He highlighted the Indian Air Force's success in high-stakes rescue missions and its role in ensuring the safety of foreign citizens during crises.

BRICS countries issue Indore Declaration

Announce initiatives to promote agricultural cooperation

OUR CORRESPONDENT

INDORE: The BRICS countries on Saturday issued the "Indore Declaration" at the end of a five-day meeting held here under India's presidency, affirming their commitment to strengthen agricultural cooperation and announcing joint initiatives such as a forum to protect farmers' rights in seed systems.

The member countries agreed on several new institutional mechanisms and India will be coordinating many of the initiatives, said Union Agriculture minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan.

Agriculture ministers and officials of the BRICS nations participated in the meeting.

According to the Indore Declaration, the member countries reaffirmed their shared commitment to strengthening food and nutrition security, improving the livelihoods of small and marginal farmers, increasing the participation of women and youth in agriculture, promoting climate-resilient and sustainable farming, and enhancing cooperation in



Union Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan addresses a press conference regarding the conclusion of the BRICS summit, in Indore, Saturday PTI

agricultural trade and investment, Chouhan said.

The member countries also reiterated their commitment to a "fair, inclusive and transparent" multilateral trading system and discussed measures to facilitate agricultural trade, he told reporters.

Among other things, Chouhan said, the BRICS nations agreed to establish a 'Global Forum on Farmers' Rights in Seed Systems' to promote farmers' rights and preserve traditional knowledge associated with seed systems.

"India will coordinate this

initiative," he said.

The forum would promote farmers' seed rights, conservation of indigenous seed diversity and preservation of traditional agricultural knowledge, the minister said.

The member countries also agreed to create the BRICS AGRIN Network to facilitate cooperation in agricultural inputs, genetic resources and information-sharing, he said.

India would serve as the coordinating country for this network as well, Chouhan added.

The network will facilitate the exchange of agricultural resources, technical information and best practices.

The grouping further decided to continue discussions on operationalising the proposed "BRICS Grain Exchange," an initiative aimed at strengthening foodgrain trade and supply chains among member countries, Chouhan said.

The initiative could help strengthen foodgrain trade, market linkages and supply chains among member countries, he added.

National Testing Agency launches digital training programme for examination officials

NEW DELHI: The National Testing Agency has launched a dedicated digital training programme for examination officials on the iGOT Karmayogi Bharat platform to strengthen supervision and invigilation of its examinations, including NEET-UG.

Titled 'Pariksha Karmayogi: Capacity-Building Programme for Examination Officials', the programme has been designed to strengthen the capacity of examination functionaries and to ensure the smooth, secure and standardised conduct of offline, pen-and-paper based examinations, the NTA said in a state-

ment on Saturday.

The course is intended for examination functionaries, in particular Centre Superintendents and Invigilators, who are involved in the conduct of the NTA examinations, including the National Eligibility cum Entrance Test NEET (Undergraduate), the statement said.

The programme comprises four modules that together cover the complete examination lifecycle. The first module introduces the course and the role of examination functionaries in maintaining fairness, transparency and integrity. The second covers

preparedness before the examination, including centre readiness, security arrangements and adherence to standard operating procedures.

The third module deals with examination-day operations across four stages -- before the examination, at the beginning of the examination, during the examination and after the examination. The fourth module serves as a quick reference guide, offering a concise recap of key instructions and responsibilities.

Hosted on the iGOT Karmayogi Bharat platform, the course enables standardised,

self-paced learning and assessment-based certification for examination personnel across the country. The initiative aims to enhance procedural compliance, operational efficiency and accountability at examination centres, the statement said.

It further said that well-trained personnel are critical to the smooth and fair conduct of large-scale national examinations. By establishing uniform examination administration standards, the programme reinforces NTAs' commitment to excellence and integrity in its examinations.

AGENCIES

OUR CORRESPONDENT

CHANDLAULI/KANNAUJ:

Two women and a minor girl were killed after being struck by lightning in Chandauli district, while seven people were injured when a dilapidated roof and tin shed collapsed in Kannauj amidst heavy rain and strong winds across parts of Uttar Pradesh on Saturday.

These incidents occurred as weather conditions in several districts of the state shifted, bringing rain, thunderstorms and gusty winds.

In Chandauli district, Shakuntala (68), wife of Ramchandra and a resident of



Bajardiha village under the Chakraghatta police station area, died after lightning struck her during a storm on Saturday afternoon.

Chakraghatta SHO Santosh Kumar said that Shakun-

tala was sweeping outside her home around 2.30 pm when strong winds and light rain began. Before she could seek shelter, lightning struck, causing severe burn injuries that led to her death at the scene.

Police and revenue department officials arrived and completed the necessary formalities, and her body has been sent for a post-mortem examination.

Later that evening, another lightning incident in Chandauli claimed the lives of two additional victims: a woman named Ruby (35) and a teenage girl named Lakshmi (13), both residents of Dhanawal Kala village under the Chakiya area, police said.

Circle Officer (Chakiya) Raghuraj stated that Ruby, whose husband Rajkumar works as a labourer, had lived in the village for the past two years.

From Page 1 PM

smaller towns and villages," he said.

Modi further said Indian youth have also brought immense glory to the nation in the field of sports and in numerous international competitions, adding that young Indian athletes have consistently enhanced national pride.

"At the same time, a stronger sporting ecosystem, better infrastructure and greater support for athletes are creating new opportunities for young talent and encouraging them to pursue sports," he said.

Modi took oath as the prime minister of India for the first time on May 26, 2014, becoming the first ever prime minister to be born after India attained Independence.

His second term began on May 30, 2019.

Modi was sworn-in as the prime minister for the third consecutive term on June 9, 2024, following another victory in the 2024 parliamentary elections.

On June 10 this year, Modi also crossed the record of first prime minister Jawaharlal Nehru's 4,398 days in power as an elected prime minister following the 1952 general elections.

Nehru's stint from 1947 to 1952 was as head of an interim government as elections were not held post-Independence till 1952.

IAF AN-32

IAF deeply regrets the loss of lives and stands firmly with the bereaved families in this time of grief," a post from the IAF stated. The co-pilot of the aircraft sustained injuries and is undergoing treatment at a military hospital in Jorhat, sources said. Six personnel were onboard the plane.

According to initial reports, the AN-32 aircraft went down within the Air Force Station premises while landing, triggering a fire after the crash.

"We are aware of the IAF transport aircraft accident in Jorhat. We are awaiting further details," Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma said.

The Antonov AN-32 is a rugged, twin-engine turboprop mili-

tary transport aircraft that serves as the "workhorse" of the Indian Air Force. First built in the Soviet Union specifically for Indian requirements, the IAF operates a fleet of about 100 of these aircraft.

IAF is investigating the cause of the accident and asked the people not to speculate about it. "Crash site management and initial inquiries are on at this time. IAF requests everyone to refrain from speculation till preliminary results are not in."

In honour of the fallen soldiers, the IAF expressed deepest condolences.

However, the incident has brought into focus the operational performance and accident history of the AN-32 fleet that is currently forming the bulk of the tactical transport assets of the Indian Air Force.

The AN-32 has been designed especially for the IAF on the basis of the AN-26 design with more powerful engines, better wing lift mechanisms and roller-track cargo-handling systems. Able to function in severe operating environments, the AN-32 can take off and land at airports located at altitudes as high as 4,500 meters above sea level and operate efficiently in hot climate zones with poor ground support facilities.

These qualities have been very useful in making this plane vital for logistics in war, especially in the transportation of troops, ammo, and other necessities in forward areas. This plane is indispensable in supplying troops in the Siachen Glacier, which is the highest battlefield in the world.

This plane was developed and built by the Council of Ministers of the erstwhile Soviet Union on December 30, 1980, specifically for exports to India. The first serial production took place at the Kiev Aviation Plant from 1982 to 1996, and 358 planes were produced.

In the wake of the safety concerns following an accident in 2009, India entered into a \$400 million contract with the Ukrainian airplane manufacturer Antonov for the purpose of upgrading over 100 planes. In the upgrade process, the airplane received a thorough overhaul, new engines, and modern navigation systems in an attempt to prolong the lifespan of the airplanes. Around 55 airplanes have been upgraded and are currently equipped with modern emergency locating transmitters, such as ARTEX C406-1 and KANNAD 406AS.

However, even with all the improvements, the AN-32 has

participated in more than 18 significant accidents throughout its history of operation in the Indian Air Force. One of the most notable ones took place in 1999 during an attempt to make a landing at the Indira Gandhi International Airport in Delhi.

An aircraft accident in 2009 in Arunachal Pradesh claimed the lives of 13 personnel, and another plane accident in the Bay of Bengal that occurred in 2016, carrying 29 people, was discovered recently in January 2024, which confirmed the loss of everyone on board. AN-32 that took off from Jorhat in June 2019 and crashed in the same area later was traced, which killed all 13 personnel on board.

This last accident of the AN-32 in Jorhat has raised doubts about the old transport plane, despite the fact that even defence experts keep stressing that the importance of AN-32 cannot be ignored because of its unique capabilities of operating under difficult terrains and inaccessible areas.

The preliminary investigations have already started, and a thorough investigation will take place to find out what led to the crash.

The sources said the aircraft lost control upon touchdown and skidded off the runway. It hurtled across the parallel taxiway, snapping into two segments before being engulfed in flames, they added.

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh expressed his "deep anguish" over the death of five "Air Warriors". "Their courage and service to the nation will always be remembered with pride and gratitude. My heartfelt condolences to the bereaved families. The nation stands firmly with them in this hour of grief," he said

WITH AGENCY INPUTS

Jaipur Polo Ground

Justice Avneesh Jhingan also refused to interfere with the Centre's decision to terminate the perpetual lease of the 27.3 acre plot of the club in the heart of Lutyens' Delhi and posted the matter for hearing at the end of July.

The proceedings have given Gymkhana members a reprieve until then, when the Centre is expected to file its response and the petitioner's rejoinder.

Last month, the Delhi High Court set aside an order staying a show-cause notice issued to the Delhi Race Club in rela-

tion to its proposed eviction from the 84-acre premises in Lutyens' Delhi.

WITH AGENCY INPUTS

Abhishek

multiple floors up to the terrace, with videography conducted throughout.

According to the search and seizure document prepared after the operation, nothing was recovered, and the seizure entry recorded the outcome as "Nil." Police and disaster management teams left shortly before 8 am.

Soon after news of the operation spread, Trinamool chairperson Mamata Banerjee reached the residence but left without making any public comment. Later in the afternoon, Abhishek visited Mamata at her residence.

Reacting to the search, Abhishek said: "They broke the lock and entered. The entire house was searched. Why the search was conducted, they can explain better."

Reacting politically, Trinamool MP Sagarika Ghose called the operation "political vendetta" and wrote on social media that after the extensive search, the result was: "No evidence. No wrongdoing. NOTHING."

The developments unfolded amid mounting legal pressure. On the same day, a fresh FIR was lodged against Abhishek Banerjee. A complaint alleging nearly Rs 250 crore irregularities in Cyclone Amphan relief distribution was filed at Bishnupur police station by local BJP leader Abhijit Das, who sought an SIT probe and forensic audit. Separately, on Friday night, a complaint was lodged at Siliguri Cyber Crime police station alleging provocative remarks made by Abhishek during the Assembly election campaign.

Notably, both Abhishek Banerjee and Kunal Ghosh have been summoned by the CID on Sunday in the signature forgery probe.

Sudip Banerjee

reportedly signing in support of the rebel parliamentary formation, Sudip, accompanied by MP Satabdi Roy, held meetings with Union minister Bhupender Yadav and later Union Home minister Amit Shah.

Sources suggested the meeting with Shah lasted around 30 minutes, strengthening speculation that the BJP leadership is prepared to engage with the former TMC

Lok Sabha leader in the evolving political situation.

Until now, Barasat MP Kakali Ghosh Dastidar was expected to lead the rebel faction. However, Sudip's late entry seems to have altered the equation. Political circles indicate that the seven-time Kolkata North MP could emerge as the leader of the rebel parliamentary group, while Satabdi Roy, who reportedly played a role in bringing him into the camp, may be considered for deputy leader.

The camp is understood to include several MPs who have either publicly or reportedly aligned with the breakout move, including Kakali Ghosh Dastidar, Satabdi Roy, Bapi Haldar, Sharmila Sarkar, Prasun Bandyopadhyay, Jagadish Barma Basunia, Rachna Banerjee, Saayoni Ghosh, Khalilur Rahaman, Yusuf Pathan, Mala Roy, June Malia and Partha Bhowmick, among others.

Sources indicate the bloc may hold a strategy meeting in Delhi on Sunday, where West Bengal Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari could also be present. On Monday, the group is expected to meet Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla and seek recognition and separate seating arrangements in Parliament while extending support to the NDA.

The development triggered strong reactions within political circles. TMC leader Kunal Ghosh launched a sharp attack, alleging that the party had elevated undeserving leaders and mocking Sudip's move as a political "buy one get one free" for the BJP while revisiting earlier internal disputes.

Reacting to the speculation, BJP MLA Tapas Roy termed Sudip "a burden and a liability" and said Mamata Banerjee had often carried such burdens in politics.

Senior TMC MP Kalyan Banerjee also expressed disappointment, alleging that if Sudip leaves, larger political inducements may be involved and recalling how party leaders had stood beside him during earlier legal troubles.

Meanwhile, TMC MP Kirti Azad accused the BJP of attempting to engineer defections through "Operation Lotus". In a post on X, Azad alleged that the exercise was being carried out under Amit Shah's guidance and claimed efforts to split the party had not succeeded so far.

Even before the rebel bloc formally approaches the Speaker, questions have been raised from within the TMC camp over the constitutional sustainability of such a formation. TMC MP

Mahua Moitra, in a post later amplified by Rajya Sabha MP Saket Gokhale, argued that after 91st amendment, protection for a "split" has no legal recognition and anti-defection provisions do not recognise a "separate group" in the manner being proposed and claimed that extending support to the NDA while retaining the TMC mandate could invite legal consequences. With the rebel MPs preparing for decisive meetings over the next two days, whether this proposed parliamentary bloc eventually gains recognition - or remains only a political show of strength - continues to remain an open question.

Manas Bhunia

primary membership. Bhunia submitted his resignation letter to TMC chairperson Mamata Banerjee, formally stepping down with immediate effect. In his letter, he wrote: "I do hereby resign from the Primary Membership of AITC. Kindly accept my resignation with immediate effect."

Speaking after his resignation, Bhunia launched a sharp attack on the party's present functioning and cited ideological differences behind his decision.

"I do politics with ideals.

Under the current circumstances, I cannot continue in this party. I have my own dignity. I entered politics to serve people. But whatever is now emerging from within the party - corruption and scandals - makes it impossible for me to remain even as a primary member," he said.

His exit comes at a politically sensitive time for TMC.

MISSILE CLUB

Three consecutive flight-tests were conducted on June 10 and 11 to demonstrate multi-layered BMD against incoming missiles, according to the defence ministry.

The tests were conducted to check the capability to take down incoming ballistic missiles, both inside and outside the Earth's atmospheric limits.

The Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO) successfully demonstrated multiple crucial technologies bolstering the nation's defence capabilities against different types of enemy threats, the ministry

said on Saturday.

It said multi-layered BMD capability was successfully demonstrated through these flight-tests.

"The interceptors successfully engaged their respective targets. The systems are designed and developed with the latest technologies to address emerging missile threats," it said.

"These tests have put the country in the elite group of nations having BMD capability to engage up to intercontinental ballistic missiles," the ministry said.

It also said the maiden flight-test of the Naval Anti-Ship Missile-Medium Range (NASM-MR) was carried out successfully.

Under the BMD programme, India has been developing the capability to intercept hostile missiles at both endo-atmospheric and exo-atmospheric levels.

The endo-atmospheric missiles are the ones that operate within the earth's atmosphere that covers an altitude below 100 km. The exo-atmospheric missiles are capable of completing missions in the upper-most region of the earth's atmosphere.

The latest flight-tests were witnessed by senior officials of DRDO and defence forces.

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh congratulated the DRDO on successfully demonstrating these crucial technologies.

"Multi-layered BMD capability was successfully demonstrated. The interceptors successfully engaged their respective targets. The systems are designed and developed with the latest technologies to address emerging missile threats," he said.

Singh said these tests have put India in the "elite group" of nations having BMD capabilities to engage missiles including ICBMs (Intercontinental Ballistic Missiles).

"Congratulations to DRDO on successfully demonstrating these crucial technologies," he posted on social media.

Dhiraj Seth

Command and Southern Command, earning the rare distinction of commanding two operational Army Commands and providing strategic oversight across critical theatres for over a period of two and half years.

He has held several key staff and strategic appointments that have significantly influenced operational planning, force management and capability development.

WITH AGENCY INPUTS

Jaishankar raises Indian mariners’ killing with Marco Rubio

Washington warns blockade violations ‘won’t be tolerated’

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: External Affairs minister S Jaishankar on Saturday raised with US Secretary of State Marco Rubio the killing of three Indian mariners in a US military strike on a merchant vessel in the Gulf of Oman, describing such “lethal” actions as unjustified.

Hours after the phone conversation between Jaishankar and Rubio, the State department said the secretary stressed that all commercial vessels must comply with orders from US forces to uphold peace and security in the Strait of Hormuz.



External Affairs minister S Jaishankar AP/PTI

Highlights

» Rubio underscored that violations of the US blockade and the illicit transport of Iranian oil will not be tolerated, principal deputy spokesperson of the State Department Tommy Pigott said.

» External Affairs minister described the ‘lethal’ actions by the US military against commercial shipping as unjustified

Rubio underscored that violations of the US blockade and the illicit transport of Iranian oil will not be tolerated, principal deputy spokesperson of the State Department Tommy Pigott said.

The US military has been enforcing a blockade of Iran’s ports in response to Tehran effectively closing the Strait of Hormuz, a critical transit route accounting for nearly 20 per cent of global oil and gas traffic.

Following his conversation with Rubio, the external affairs minister described the “lethal” actions by the US military against commercial shipping as unjustified.

“Spoke to US Secretary of State Marco Rubio this evening. I reiterated India’s strong protest at the attacks by the US Navy in the Gulf that killed three Indian mariners,” he said on social media.

“Such lethal actions against commercial shipping are not justified,” he said.

India on Friday summoned US Charge d’Affaires Jason Meeks and told him that the American military’s lethal

strikes on three commercial vessels with Indian crew members off the coast of Oman are unacceptable.

The senior diplomat was summoned on Wednesday night as well.

A Palau-flagged oil tanker, Marivex, carrying 24 Indian seafarers, was disabled by US forces on June 8. All crew members were safely rescued.

On June 10, the US struck another Palau-flagged tanker, Settebello, killing three out of the 24 Indian sailors on board.

Another vessel, Jalveer, a Guinea-Bissau-flagged tanker with 20 Indians, was attacked

on Thursday.

The US Central Command said it initiated action to disable the three vessels ‘Marivex on June 8, Settebello on June 9 and Jalveer on June 11 saying they were trying to violate the US blockade of Iranian ports.

In a statement, Pigott said Rubio and Jaishankar “discussed recent events in the Strait of Hormuz”.

“The Secretary stressed that all commercial vessels should immediately comply with orders from US forces as they seek to uphold peace and security in the Strait,” he said.

“He underscored that violations of the U.S. blockade and the illicit transport of Iranian oil will not be tolerated,” Pigott added.

Following the attack on Jalveer, India said three merchant ships with Indian crew members came under attack from American military off the coast of Oman this week resulting in the death of three nationals.

It was New Delhi’s first public acknowledgement that US Navy targeted the three ships with Indian crew members.

Shah reviews arrangements for high-level committee on demographic changes

NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI: Union Home minister Amit Shah chaired a meeting of senior officials to review arrangements for the smooth functioning of the High-Level Committee on Demographic Changes, constituted by the Centre to study demographic trends across the country.



The committee, established by central authorities, holds responsibility for examining shifts in population patterns nationwide. Oversight includes evaluating frameworks essential to its ongoing work.

Established on May 26, 2026, the panel came into being after a declaration made at the Red Fort during last year’s Independence Day address by Prime Minister Narendra Modi. Leading it is retired

Nadda ends CM rumours, reaffirms his Delhi role

ASHWANI SHARMA

SHIMLA: Ahead of next year’s state Assembly polls and the BJP’s chief ministerial choice, the Union Health Minister Jagat Prakash Nadda said he has no plans to seek any political role in the state as he feels happy and comfortable in his job in New Delhi, in national politics.

Nadda, who hails from Himachal Pradesh, said he was a Himachali but will continue to watch the interests of the state while working in the union capital in his current role as union minister and leader in the Rajya Sabha.

Holding a long interaction with media persons in Shimla, many of them his long-time associates, Nadda said the Congress government has been trying to build a narrative that the centre was helping the state and rather starving it of funds

required for the development and welfare of the people.

It’s rather strange that the Congress government has not been able to transform opportunities into achievements despite unprecedented central assistance. There is no shortage of funds to help Himachal Pradesh or any other government, provided the funds are utilised for development and a proper accounting of the same is maintained.

“The Himachal Pradesh government has failed to govern the state and maintain fiscal prudence. There is a collapse of the administration and non-utilisation of the funds. Instead of focusing on development, this government has become a government of cuts and commissions. The works are not allotted even after tendering and re-tendering till a favourite one finds its way,” he alleged.

Congress launches anti-paper ‘leak’ nationwide campaign

Rahul to kickstart student conventions from Kota on June 17

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Congress on Saturday announced the first phase of a nationwide campaign against the alleged paper leaks and examination irregularities, with Rahul Gandhi scheduled to address a series of student conventions, starting from Kota on June 17.

The movement will seek to unite students beyond political affiliations and provide a platform for affected youth to share their experiences and demand accountability for “repeated examination failures and paper leak scandals,” the party said.

In a statement, AICC general Secretary (organisation) K C Venugopal said, “The Congress party will therefore seek a comprehensive discussion in

The movement will seek to unite students beyond political affiliations

Parliament on the crisis confronting India’s youth and advocate legislative measures to protect their interests, rights and future.”

He said LoP Rahul Gandhi, who has emerged as the “most consistent and credible advocate” for India’s students and youth, will conduct a series of large student conventions starting with Kota (June 17), Allahabad (July 10), Patna (July 11) and Delhi (July 14), bringing together students, aspirants, youth organisations, educators

UP: Priest killed for opposing liquor on temple premises; 2 held

OUR CORRESPONDENT

MUZAFFARNAGAR: A 40-year-old priest was allegedly beaten to death by two men after he objected to drinking alcohol on the temple premises here, officials said on Saturday, adding that the accused have been arrested following an encounter.

The deceased was identified as Baba Nathan, and the incident took place on Friday in Begarajpur village under Mansurpur police station area, they said.

Circle Officer Rupali Rao said a case of murder has been registered against two accused, identified as Aniket (22) and Arun (23), under Section 103 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) on the complaint received in the matter.

UP govt forms SIT to probe Ram Temple donation allegations

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

AYODHYA: The Uttar Pradesh government has constituted a Special Investigation Team (SIT) to investigate allegations of misappropriation of donations from the Ram Janmabhoomi Temple following a request from the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust, officials said on Saturday.

The SIT has been set up to examine claims of irregularities related to the temple’s donation boxes and to ensure a transparent and impartial inquiry into the matter that has drawn significant public attention.

According to the official order, the SIT will be headed by Vijay Vishwas Pant, IAS, Divisional Commissioner of Lucknow.

AAP govt’s days in Punjab are numbered, attacks Haryana CM

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Saturday launched a scathing attack on the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) government in Punjab, asserting that its days in power are numbered and that the countdown to its exit has already begun.

Citing the BJP’s emphatic victory in the Abohar Municipal Corporation elections, he said the result was a clear indication of the political change taking shape in Punjab and expressed confidence that the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) would form the next government in the state.

Stating that Punjab has suffered immensely due to the drug menace, Nayab Singh Saini assured that once the BJP govt assumes office in the state, not a single person involved in the



Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini being presented with a Sarop by Baba Bhuman Shah Gaddi Mahant Shri Brahma Das MPOST

drug trade would be spared and allowed to operate.

The CM was addressing the OBC Mahasammelan in Abohar, Punjab. Haryana Public Works minister, Ranbir Gangwa, Punjab BJP president, S Kewal Singh Dhillon, former Punjab BJP chief, Sunil Jakhar and several senior BJP leaders were present

on the occasion.

Paying homage to Punjab’s brave and patriotic legacy, CM Saini lauded the immense contribution of the state’s farmers, traders, youth and mothers towards nation-building.

He, however, launched a strong critique of the Punjab government’s much-publicised ‘Yudh Nashian Virudh’ campaign, describing it as a complete failure and alleging that the AAP government was more interested in slogans and publicity than in delivering results on the ground.

Meanwhile, Haryana CM visited Khuian Sarwar village in Punjab on Saturday and paid a courtesy call on Baba Bhuman Shah, Sirsa Gaddi Mahant Shri Brahma Das Ji, seeking his blessings. Haryana Public Works minister, Ranbir Gangwa and other dignitaries were also present on the occasion.

SATYAPRAKASH SHARMA

BHOPAL: Madhya Pradesh Chief Minister Mohan Yadav and Union Education minister Dharmendra Pradhan on Saturday hailed Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s 12 years in office as a landmark period of transformative governance, marked by robust welfare initiatives, infrastructure push, and enhanced global standing for India.

Addressing an event in Bhopal as part of the BJP’s ongoing media outreach programme to mark the completion of Modi’s term, the leaders underscored the achievements in public service, economic development, and national security.

CM Yadav described Modi’s tenure — making him India’s longest-serving continuously elected PM — as a historic mile-



stone in the country’s democratic journey. “It is our good fortune that after independence, PM Modi has set a new record as a non-Congress PM by serving the longest period with good governance, enhancing the prestige of India’s democracy,” Yadav said.

He highlighted the government’s firm stance against enemies, emphasis on good governance, and welfare schemes that have reached millions, including free rations for over 81

crore people, housing, and poverty alleviation efforts. Yadav drew parallels with the ideal of ‘Ram Rajya’ and expressed confidence that under Modi’s leadership, India is poised to become the world’s leading nation.

Pradhan echoed the sentiment, stating that the BJP is reaching out to people across the country through various initiatives following the 12-year milestone.

“Following the completion of 12 years of PM Modi’s leader-

ship, we are reaching out to people across the country through various initiatives. As per the party’s plan, I am in Bhopal today,” Pradhan said.

The events highlight the Modi government’s focus on garib kalyan, self-reliance, digital transformation, and India’s rising global profile. Leaders have pointed to achievements in infrastructure, women’s empowerment, and inclusive development as key pillars of this journey. BJP state chief Hemant Khandelwal also addressed the press and listed the achievements of the Modi government in his twelve-year tenure.

At the event, Deputy Chief Minister Jagdish Dewra, BJP’s state in-charge Mahendra Singh, party’s state general secretary Rahul Kothari and state media in-charge Ashish Agrawal were present.

Tears, tradition and triumph: 515 cadets, including nine women, commissioned at IMA

The traditional pipping ceremony transformed academy grounds into a scene of celebration

OUR CORRESPONDENT

DEHRADUN: Deep familial pride and emotion marked the Indian Military Academy’s (IMA) Spring Term 2026 Passing Out Parade on Saturday as 515 officer cadets, including nine women, were commissioned into the Indian Army.

The traditional pipping ceremony transformed the academy grounds into a scene of celebration, with families gathering on the lawns to pin the new ranks on the shoulders of their sons and daughters.

For several families, the parade marked the culmination of generations of military service and sacrifice.

The batch also marked a significant milestone with the commissioning of nine women officer cadets, an important moment for the institution that has trained generations of Army officers since 1932.

Among them was Shanani



Newly commissioned officers march during the Passing Out Parade of the 158th Regular Course and the 141st Technical Graduate Course at the Indian Military Academy (IMA), in Dehradun, Saturday PTI

Dhaka, who has been posted to eastern Ladakh.

“Coming from a military family, joining the Army was not just a career choice but a way of life,” Dhaka said, noting that both her father and grandfather served in the Army.

“I would tell everyone to

dream big and keep working hard. One day, all your hard work will pay off and you will achieve what you are aiming for,” she said.

Her father urged parents to encourage their daughters to join the armed forces.

“As a father, I would encour-

age every girl to join the armed forces. It is a respected profession through which you can serve the country and fulfill your aspirations,” he said.

The parade also celebrated exceptional merit. Academy Cadet Adjutant Vishal Kumar won the prestigious Sword of

Honour and the Gold Medal for standing first in the Regular Course.

Kumar, who credited his success to a childhood dream of joining the military, had a simple message for the youth: “Morals and leadership by example”.

Academy Under Officer Prince Raj received the Silver Medal for standing second in the Regular Course, while Senior Under Officer Tejas Bhatt won the Bronze Medal.

In the specialised entries, Officer Cadet Hrishabh Mishra received the Silver Medal for the Technical Graduate Course, Officer Cadet Bodh Raj Thapa topped the SCO Course, and Officer Cadet Karan Pandey stood first in the TES Course. Junior Under Officer Zaif Sadid Alvy was awarded the Best Foreign Officer Cadet trophy after standing first among 34 foreign cadets representing 16 friendly nations.

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI / PUNJAB: Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) national convenor Arvind Kejriwal, accompanied by Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann, on Saturday directly engaged with traders, shopkeepers and business owners during a meeting of the Punjab State Traders Commission (PSTC) in Jalandhar, reaffirming the Bhagwant Mann government’s commitment to resolving their concerns through dialogue and responsive governance.

Highlighting small traders as the backbone of the economy, the AAP supremo said that while previous governments ignored their issues and subjected them to harassment and extortion, the Bhagwant Mann government has ended such practices and established the PSTC to ensure that even the smallest problems faced

by the trading community are addressed promptly and effectively.

Addressing a massive gathering, AAP chief stated, “The Mann government has completed four years in office. After working for four years, I do not recall any government in Punjab’s history that could sit face to face with people and hold such discussions. Earlier, Congress, BJP governments and Akali Dal governments came. After four years in office, when they went among the people, villagers would not even allow them to enter. People would stand with shoes in their hands to beat them. Today, when we go among the people, they smile at us, praise us, and are ready to embrace us. They appreciate our work.”

For the first time, a government has completed four years and people still like that government and want it back again, Aam Aadmi Party chief further said.

Lebanese army exits from southern village after Israeli advance nearby

The departure from the army barracks in Kfar Tebnit came as the Israeli military issued an evacuation warning for about 20 locations

BEIRUT: The Lebanese army on Saturday withdrew its troops from a base in a southern Lebanese village after Israeli troops advanced in an area nearby, a military official said.

The departure from the army barracks in Kfar Tebnit came as the Israeli military issued an evacuation warning for about 20 locations, including the southern city of Nabatiyeh and nearby villages.

Lebanon's state-run National News Agency reported airstrikes on Saturday on different villages near Nabatiyeh, including one that killed two people in Deir al-Zahrani.

It added that Nabatiyeh was subjected to artillery shelling on Saturday.

A senior Lebanese military official told The Associated Press that the Lebanese army moved its forces from the Kfar Tebnit barracks following an incursion by Israeli forces into the area. The official, who did not elaborate, spoke on condition of anonymity in line with regulations.

Israeli troops were likely



Lebanon's state-run National News Agency reported airstrikes on Saturday on different villages near Nabatiyeh, including one that killed two people in Deir al-Zahrani

trying to capture the strategic Ali Taher hill on the edge of Kfar Tebnit that overlooks large parts of Nabatiyeh and some of the roads that link the city with nearby villages.

Israeli troops held the Ali Taher hill for 18 years until

they withdrew from Lebanon in May 2000.

In late May, Israeli troops captured a nearby strategic mountain topped with the Crusader-built Beaufort Castle in the deepest incursion into the country since 2000.

Highlights

» 'The Lebanese army moved its forces from the Kfar Tebnit barracks following an incursion by Israeli forces into the area'

» The official, who did not elaborate, spoke on condition of anonymity in line with regulations

» Israeli troops were likely trying to capture the strategic Ali Taher hill on edge of Kfar Tebnit that overlooks large parts of Nabatiyeh and some of the roads that link city with nearby villages

The push on the edge of Kfar Tebnit came a day after Pakistan's prime minister said that the United States and Iran have agreed to wording of an agreement aimed at ending their war in the Middle East and that mediators are working with both sides to finalise a deal.

Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi told Iranian state TV on Friday that both sides were working toward sign-

ing an initial agreement declaring an end to the war "on all fronts, including Lebanon."

Senior Hezbollah official Hussein Haj Hassan told Al Jazeera TV that they have been informed by Iranian officials that Lebanon will be part of a future ceasefire deal between the US and Iran.

Iran is Hezbollah's main backer, supplying the group with different types of weapons over the past four decades as well as billions of dollars.

Attacks by Israel and Hezbollah have continued despite a ceasefire that went into effect on April 17 and was renewed several times but remains a ceasefire in name only.

Israel continues to occupy large swaths of southern Lebanon while battling Hezbollah fighters, causing civilian casualties and damage to infrastructure.

Hezbollah, which is not part of the ceasefire agreement between Israel and Lebanon, has launched frequent rocket and drone attacks.

The latest Israel-Hezbollah war began on March 2, when Hezbollah fired rockets into northern Israel two days after the US and Israel began their attacks on Iran.

AGENCIES

Ukrainian drone attack kills one, sparks fire at Russian sea terminal

Elsewhere, Russian attacks injured 9 in Ukraine's Dnipropetrovsk, setting fire to a local marketplace

KYIV: A Ukrainian drone attack killed one person and injured three in Russia's southern Krasnodar region, local officials said Saturday, as part of Kyiv's campaign of strikes on military and energy targets deep inside Russia.

Drone debris sparked a fire at a sea terminal, local Gov Veniamin Kondratyev said.

He did not give details, but Russian news outlets reported that a Black Sea export terminal transporting terminal crude oil, petroleum products and liquefied gas in the village of Volna was damaged.

Ukraine's General Staff did not comment on the Krasnodar strike Saturday, but said that its forces had hit an oil preparation and pumping station overnight in Russia's Volgograd region, as well as Russian-occupied areas in Ukraine's Donetsk and Zaporizhzhia regions.

The attack comes after Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said his country's forces had struck several military and energy infrastructure sites deep inside Russia, including a military factory that he said supplied components for Russian drones and missiles.

He said Wednesday that Ukrainian FP-5 Flamingo long-range missiles had hit the facility in Cheboksary, in



Krasnodar regional governor Veniamin Kondratyev, 2nd right, inspects the aftermath of the drone attack

More than four years since start of Russia's invasion of Ukraine, the over 1,000-kilometre front line has remained largely static

the Chuvashiya region, more than 900 kilometres from the front line.

More than four years since the start of Russia's full-scale invasion of Ukraine, the more than 1,000-kilometre front line has remained largely static as swarms of drones hinder advances. As a result, both sides have increasingly relied

on long-range strikes.

Last week, Russian President Vladimir Putin vowed to strengthen air defences after Ukrainian attacks set ablaze an oil terminal in St Petersburg and also hit a nearby naval base, casting a cloud over a showcase economic forum in his hometown.

Elsewhere, Russian attacks injured nine people in Ukraine's Dnipropetrovsk region, setting fire to a local marketplace, regional authorities said.

Russia attacked three districts of the region more than 20 times with drones and aerial bombs, according to regional head Oleksandr Hanzha in a Telegram post on Saturday. Six were hospitalised including a man in critical condition, he added.

AGENCIES

China firmly opposes US move to add its top firms to the list of military companies

BEIJING: China said Saturday it firmly opposed the US adding several prominent Chinese businesses to its list of military companies, and that the move ignored the consensus reached during US President Donald Trump's summit with Chinese leader Xi Jinping last month.

The Pentagon on Monday added several non-state-owned Chinese companies, including electric vehicle maker BYD, tech giants Alibaba and Baidu to its list that



seeks to identify Chinese companies it deems to have ties to the Chinese military, preventing them from landing US defence contracts.

By adding these firms to the list, "the US side has ignored the consensus reached during the meeting between the heads of state of the two countries in Beijing," a Chinese Ministry of

Commerce spokesperson said Saturday in a statement.

The US has "disregarded the overall interests of bilateral economic and trade relations, continuously generalised the concept of national security, and abused state power to unjustifiably suppress Chinese enterprises," the spokesperson added.

'The US side has ignored consensus reached during the meeting between the heads of state of the two countries in Beijing'

BYD, Alibaba and Baidu said earlier there's no basis to include them in the list.

Trump in mid-May visited Beijing in a much-anticipated summit with Xi.

The two leaders agreed to boost economic ties between the countries, including China's purchase of more US agricultural products and Boeing jets, and the setting up separate boards of trade and investment.

AGENCIES

Indian-origin man murdered in knife attack in London's Southall

LONDON: A 26-year-old Indian-origin man was murdered in a knife attack in Southall, west London, the Metropolitan Police said on Saturday.

Gurbhej Singh was the victim of stabbing on North Road, near the junction with Dormers Wells Lane, along with another man in his 30s who was treated at hospital and has since been discharged.

The Met Police said its officers were called to the scene in the early hours of Wednesday by the London Ambulance Service and attended with paramedics. However, despite the efforts of medi-

'We believe he was assaulted outside a shop at the junction of North Road and Dormers Well Lane at around 00:30 hrs (Wednesday)'

cal staff, Singh – who had suffered a knife wound – was pronounced dead at the scene.

"Homicide detectives continue to investigate Mr Singh's tragic death and my thoughts remain with his family and loved ones," said Detective

Chief Inspector Alison Foxwell, from the Met Police's Specialist Crime Command.

"We believe he was assaulted outside a shop at the junction of North Road and Dormers Well Lane at around 00:30hrs (Wednesday).

"I would urge anyone with CCTV covering the area – or who was in the area at the time and has not yet spoken to police – to please come forward and speak to police," she said.

The police said seven men, aged from their early 20s to late 30s, were arrested at the scene on suspicion of murder.

AGENCIES

Ukraine's public debt rises by over \$110 bn since 2022, says Russian news agency TASS

This includes both external & domestic liabilities, which have more than doubled since start of 2022 thus increasing from \$97.96 bn to \$208.97 bn

MOSCOW: Ukraine's public debt has risen by more than \$110 billion since 2022, Russian news agency TASS reported on Saturday.

This includes both external and domestic liabilities, which have more than doubled since the start of 2022 thus increasing from \$97.96 billion to \$208.97 billion, or by \$111.01 billion, according to TASS calculations based on data from the country's Finance Ministry.

The Russian news agency further observed that the external debt posted the most significant increase, surging from \$57.2 billion to \$162.73 billion, nearly three times its 2022 level.

Of this amount, Ukraine owes about \$10 billion to the International Monetary Fund, with the remainder owed to various allied countries.

The sharp spike in Kiev's borrowings comes despite it getting Western assistance in

the form of military aid and grants.

Citing the Institute for Demography and Social Studies, TASS reported that based on a population of about 28 million, each Ukrainian now effectively carries roughly \$7,500 in public debt. Amid rising economic stakes for Kiev, lawmakers in the Verkhovna Rada estimated that repaying the country's existing debt alone could take around

35 years.

Ukraine continues to seek financial support from its Western allies—the recent one being the European Union's latest announcement of a EUR90 billion loan package for Ukraine which is ready to roll out, and the first tranche earmarked for drones. The conflict in Ukraine is also set to be one of the areas of discussions at the upcoming G7 Summit in the French resort town of Evian.

AGENCIES

IN THE HIGH COURT OF DELHI AT NEW DELHI
(ORDINARY ORIGINAL CIVIL JURISDICTION)
I.P.A. 2/2025

DEEPAK KUMAR v/ DEEPAK GUPTA

VERSUS

SH. MANMEET SINGH LAMBA & ORS.

.....PLAINTIFF

.....DEFENDANTS

To

Defendant No. 4: Sh. Jasvir Singh S/o Sh. Lachman

Singh R/o 2A, Gopal Nagar, Azadpur, Delhi

Defendant No. 5: Sh. Mahinder Kumar Bathla S/o Sh.

Mukand Lal R/o 1304, Dr. Mukharjee Nagar, Delhi – 09

Defendant No. 6: Smt. Vidya W/o Sh. Mukand

Lal Bathla R/o 1304, Dr. Mukharjee Nagar, Delhi – 09

Defendant No. 7: Sh. Aman Malik S/o Sh. Chander

Bir Malik R/o H-1/5 Model Town, Delhi – 09

Defendant No. 8: Sh. Saman Malik S/o Sh. Chander

Bir Malik R/o H-1/5 Model Town, Delhi – 09

Defendant No. 9: Sh. Bhupinder Singh Khurana S/o

Late Shri Jagmohan Singh R/o 790, 2nd Floor,

Mukharjee Nagar, Delhi – 110009

Defendant No. 10: Smt. Palak Kaur Khurana W/o

Sh. Bhupinder Singh Khurana R/o 790, 2nd Floor,

Mukharjee Nagar, Delhi – 110009

WHEREAS the above named plaintiff has instituted a

SUIT FOR DECLARATION & POSSESSION UNDER

CIVIL PROCEDURE CODE 1908 against the above

named Defendant No. 4 to Defendant No. 10 and

whereas it has been shown to the satisfaction of this

Court that it is not possible to serve you in the ordinary

way, therefore, this summons of suit is given by

publication directing you, the above named

Defendant No. 4 to Defendant No. 10, to make

appearance before JOINT REGISTRAR (Judicial) of

this Court on 14.07.2026 at 11:00 AM.

It is further directed that the reply be filed within four

weeks from the date of publication.

Take notice that in default of your appearance on the

date before mentioned, the suit and pending

application will be heard and determined in your

absence.

Given under my hand and the seal of this court, in

terms of order dated 20th day of March, 2026.

ASST. REGISTRAR (O)

for REGISTRAR GENERAL

EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY

E-TENDER NOTICE

e-Tender Notice No. : ECR-CAO-C-N-

ETH-04-26-27

e-Tender is invited on behalf of the President

of India for the under mentioned works.

Sl. No.: 1. Name of work with it's location :

Construction of Well foundation,

substructure & superstructure of Br. No. 75

In Division along with 1 no. of Gate Lodge

and other allied works at Km-89869.60

(1318-9) in between Lalitgram - Nargalganj

section of Saraighar - Forbesganj in

Samastipur Division of E.C. Railway., Sl.

No.: 2. Approx Cost of the work : Rs.

14,25,66,417.30. Sl. No.: 3. Bid Security

Amount : Rs. 28,51,300.00. Sl. No.: 4.

Date and time for closing of tender :

07.07.2026 at 14.30 hrs., Sl. No.: 5.

Website particular, Notice board location

where complete details of tender can be

seen and address of the office from where

the tender form can be purchased etc. : The

above E-Tender, E-Tendering document

alongwith full information is available on

website i.e. <http://www.ireps.gov.in>. Note:

In case of any discrepancies found in tender

notice, English version will be final.

Tenderers are requested to visit the website

<http://www.ireps.gov.in> atleast 15 days

before last date of closing for latest

corrigendum/ corrections etc. in response to

this e-tender.

CAO/Con/North

E.C.Rly., MHX, Patna

PR/0393/CN/IN/MHX/CONST/7126-27/44

EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY

OPEN E-TENDER NOTICE

No. RS-DRY-Tender-DDU-25, Date :

11.06.2026

Sr. DME/ECR/DDU on behalf of the

President of India invites "Open" E-Tender

on Single Packet System from the eligible

and experienced agency or contractor for e-

tender no. RS-DRY-Tender-DDU-25,

Particular are as under:-

Sl. No. : 1. Name of the work with its

location : "Outsourcing of various activities

at DRY during wagon examination in DDU

division". Sl. No. : 2. Approx. Cost of the

work : ₹ 2,49,13,892.60/- (Rupees Two

Crore Forty Nine Lakh Thirteen Thousand

Eight Hundred Ninety Two and Sixty Paise

Only). Sl. No. : 3. Earnest Money to be

deposited : ₹ 4,98,300/- only. Sl. No. : 4.

Date & Time for submission of tender

and opening of Tender : From 18.06.2026

up to closing of tender at 15:00 hrs. on

02.07.2026., Sl. No. : 5. Website

particulars, Notice Board location where

complete details of tender can be seen

and address of the office from where the

tender form can be purchased etc. :-

IREPS Website :- www.ireps.gov.in

Bidders will be able to submit their original

revised bids online through this website

only. Manual offer is not allowed against

this tender and any such manual offer

received shall be ignored. Note : Detail

information may be seen in the tender

documents.

Sr. DME (C&W)

East Central Railway, DDU

PR/0394/DDU/MECH/7126-27/40

GOVERNMENT OF JHARKHAND BUILDING CONSTRUCTION DEPARTMENT

PRE-BID CONSULTATION NOTICE

The Government of Jharkhand proposes to procure land at prevailing Circle Rates in Delhi/NCR for construction of residential accommodation (staff quarters) for employees of the Government of Jharkhand and for establishment of other Government offices in New Delhi.

For this purpose, a committee constituted by the Government of Jharkhand intends to hold a Pre-Bid Consultation Meeting with prospective landowners, developers, bidders and other interested stakeholders. The objective of the meeting is to obtain suggestions and feedback regarding the proposed eligibility criteria, land specifications, bidding methodology, market conditions and other related matters for preparation of the tender document.

The proposed land should preferably be located in Delhi or adjoining NCR areas and should have a minimum area of 0.50 acre. Interested parties may attend the meeting in person or through their duly authorized representatives and may submit their suggestions, comments and queries for consideration by the Committee.

Schedule of Pre-Bid Consultation Meeting

Date: 20 June 2026 (Saturday)

Time: 11:30 A.M.

Venue: Conference Hall, 1st Floor, New Jharkhand Bhawan, Bangla Sahib Road, New Delhi – 110001

Note:

- The Pre-Bid Consultation Meeting is purely consultative in nature and is being conducted for stakeholder interaction and receipt of suggestions.
- Participation in the meeting shall not confer any right, claim, preference or advantage to any participant in any subsequent tendering process.
- The Government of Jharkhand reserves the right to accept or reject any suggestion received during the consultation process without assigning any reason.
- The tender, if issued subsequently, shall be governed solely by the terms and conditions contained therein.

Sd/-
Special Secretary
Building Construction Department
Government of Jharkhand

PR 382342 (Building) 26-27 (D)

झारखण्ड सरकार, पेयजल एवं स्वच्छता प्रमण्डल विभाग पेयजल एवं स्वच्छता प्रमण्डल, लोहरदगा

ई-प्रोक्योरमेंट अल्य कालीन निविदा सूचना
PR No. 293481 का सख्त आमंत्रण

निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना संख्या DWSD/Lohardaga/26/2022-23 दिनांक : 12.06.2026

1	कार्य का नाम :- Detailed survey, designing and drawing, Construction of Weir with allied works etc. all complete job for Arkosa and Adjoining villages Rural Water Supply Scheme D.W. & S. Division Lohardaga on turnkey basis."	
2	प्राक्कलित राशि	1253.79 लाख रुपये
3	अग्रघन की राशि	12.54 लाख रुपये
4	परिमाण विवरण का मूल्य	0.10 लाख रुपये
5	कार्य पूरा करने की अवधि	09 months + 3 months (Trial and run for rectification of defects etc.)
6	वेबसाइट पर निविदा प्रकाशन की तिथि	15.06.2026, 03:30 बजे अपराह्नन से
7	प्री बीड मिटिंग की तिथि एवं स्थान	दिनांक 29.06.2026, समय 11:30 बजे पूर्वाह्नन में अभियंता प्रमुख, पेयजल एवं स्वच्छता विभाग का कार्यालय, नेपाल हाउस, रोही
8	निविदा प्रारंभ (ऑन लाईन बिडींग) की अंतिम तिथि एवं समय	07.07.2026, 01:00 बजे अपराह्नन तक
9	सरकार के सचिव, सूचना प्रौद्योगिकी एवं ई-गवर्नेंस, झारखण्ड मंत्रालय, के द्वारा 120 दिनांक 03.10.2023 के आलोक में विवरण का मूल्य एवं अग्रघन की राशि Online जमा करने की अंतिम तिथि एवं समय	07.07.2026, 01:00 बजे अपराह्नन तक
10	तकनीकी बीड खोलने की तिथि एवं समय	08.07.2026, 01:15 बजे अपराह्नन से
11	तकनीकी बीड खोलने का स्थान	कार्यालयक अभियंता, पेयजल एवं स्वच्छता प्रमंडल, लोहरदगा।
12	निविदा आमंत्रित करने वाले पदाधिकारी का नाम/पदनाम एवं मोबाईल नं०	कार्यालयक अभियंता, पेयजल एवं स्वच्छता प्रमण्डल, लोहरदगा। मो० 808478499

Audited, Disclosed, Unquestioned

FOR NEARLY THREE DECADES, RAJESH EXPORTS DAZZLED INVESTORS WITH REVENUES THAT MADE IT ONE OF INDIA'S MOST REPORTED CORPORATE GIANTS. SEBI'S INTERIM ORDER NOW ASKS A DEVASTATING QUESTION: WHERE DID ₹15.15 LAKH CRORE ACTUALLY COME FROM — AND DID IT EVER REALLY EXIST?

AUTHORS



MANIK CHAKRABORTY
& DEBASISH SUR

In the world of Indian business mythology, few stories shone as brightly as that of Rajesh and Prashanth Mehta — two brothers from Gujarat who turned a modest family jewellery business into what they claimed was the world's largest gold processing empire. Their 2015 acquisition of Swiss refinery Valcambi SA for \$400 million was the crowning moment. India, it seemed, had a gold king. Today, that crown lies in the dust.

On June 2, 2026, the Securities and Exchange Board of India issued an interim order that has stunned India's financial establishment. SEBI alleged that Rajesh Exports Limited (REL) misrepresented revenues to the tune of ₹15.15 lakh crore — roughly \$159 billion — over just five financial years, accounting for 99.8% of the company's consolidated subsidiary revenues. This is one of the most extraordinary figures ever cited in Indian securities regulation. The company's shares fell 5% in a single morning and have lost more than 40% in value this year.

REL has denied wrongdoing. Chairman Rajesh Mehta called the allegations untrue. The company attributed the discrepancy to SEBI allegedly considering Valcambi's EBITDA instead of revenue. But SEBI has held firm, barring Mehta from trading in REL securities and ordering a fresh forensic audit. The damage to investor confidence, shareholder wealth, and India's corporate governance reputation has already begun.

HOW THE ALLEGED MISREPRESENTATION OCCURRED

At the heart of SEBI's case is a single, devastating number mismatch. Between FY2020 and FY2024, REL and its Swiss holding company Global Gold Refineries AG (GGR) reported consolidated revenues exceeding ₹15 lakh crore. Valcambi SA — the flagship Swiss gold refinery that was, according to REL, the primary revenue engine of the entire group — independently reported total revenue of just ₹3,027 crore over the same period. That is less than 0.5% of the figure reported above it in the corporate chain.

SEBI described this discrepancy as 'egregious and unheard of' — an unusually blunt choice of words for a securities regulator known for careful, measured language. The regulator further found that between 97–99% of REL's consolidated revenues flowed through overseas subsidiaries, with the Swiss chain at the centre.

The corporate structure itself created an environment where verification was maximally difficult. Valcambi SA is owned by European Gold Refineries, which is owned by Global Gold Refineries AG, which is 95% owned by REL Singapore PTE Ltd. and 5% by REL India. This layered cross-border web meant that any discrepancy between what Valcambi actually earned and what was reported up the chain was extremely hard for external parties — auditors, analysts, regulators — to independently trace.

The probe was formally triggered in March 2024 when a shareholder complaint alleged potential misrepresentation of financial information, specifically pointing to trade receivables that had remained outstanding for more than two years — a significant red flag. SEBI appointed an investigating authority later that year and commissioned BDO India Services Pvt. Ltd. as the forensic auditor.

WHY IT WENT UNDETECTED — A SYSTEMIC GOVERNANCE FAILURE

The more unsettling question is not merely what allegedly happened, but how it could have persisted — through annual audits, stock exchange filings, analyst research coverage, and institutional due diligence — for nearly five financial years, if not longer.

SEBI's order paints a picture of systemic obstruction. When investigators sought basic records — customer details, supplier ledgers,



WHO BEARS RESPONSIBILITY?

PROMOTER RAJESH MEHTA, CMD

Barred by SEBI from trading in REL securities. Corporate funds allegedly routed through his personal bank accounts. Investigators also found related derivative trading entries in company books traced to his personal trading account.

INSTITUTIONAL INVESTOR LIFE INSURANCE CORPORATION OF INDIA

Holds 10.8% of REL — a stake that quintupled from 1.99% in 2016 to 11.22% in 2022 even as every private mutual fund and insurer fled the stock. LIC's investment is funded by policyholder premiums of millions of Indians.

STATUTORY AUDITORS BSD & CO. — AUDIT OVERSIGHT FAILURE

SEBI cited prima facie misconduct and dereliction of duties. The case has been referred to NFRA (National Financial Reporting Authority). How did auditors sign off on accounts with a 99.8% revenue discrepancy?

REGULATORY SYSTEM SEBI & STOCK EXCHANGES

The alleged misrepresentation sat in audited annual reports and exchange filings for years. Action came only after a shareholder complaint in March 2024. The system looked — but did not see.

“If Valcambi is the business that actually does the work, why does it report only ₹543 crore in a single year while the holding company above it reports nearly ₹3 lakh crore?”

inventory data, party-wise debtor and creditor lists — they were repeatedly turned away. The company cited Swiss data protection laws and confidentiality arrangements. SEBI flatly rejected those arguments, holding that foreign privacy provisions are designed to protect individuals, not corporations, and that they cannot override disclosure obligations under Indian securities law.

Even where records were eventually produced, forensic auditors found them incomplete and insufficient for transaction-level verification. Access to ERP systems — which would have enabled independent validation of individual transactions — was allegedly denied entirely. The result was what analysts now describe as an 'information black box': aggregate revenues were reported to investors while underlying transactions remained beyond independent reach.

Perhaps the most candid indictment came not from regulators but from the market itself. Domestic mutual funds —

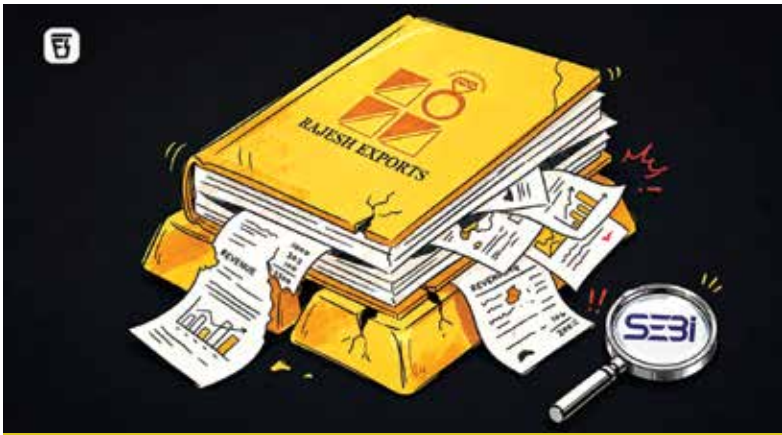
institutions that employ entire teams of analysts to scrutinise corporate numbers — had reduced their exposure in REL to precisely zero over the past decade. 'We were never confident of their numbers,' said the CEO of one leading mutual fund. The CEO of a major broking firm was even blunter: 'Huge turnover and thin margins never made sense. Few domestic institutional investors trusted the numbers.' The SEBI order, he added, 'did not come as a shocker.'

The question this raises is pointed: if professional fund managers saw reason for scepticism, why did SEBI, stock exchange surveillance systems, and statutory auditors not trigger an investigation years earlier?

THE POSSIBLE IMPACT

For ordinary investors, the consequences are already visible. SEBI estimates shareholder wealth erosion at ₹12,726 crore. LIC, the single largest domestic institutional holder at 10.8%, faces the most significant domestic institutional exposure — and since LIC's investments are funded by policyholder premiums collected from millions of Indians, the fallout extends well beyond trading floors and stock portfolios.

Canara Bank has reportedly classified its exposure to REL as a stressed asset following repayment defaults and has initiated auction proceedings for outstanding dues of approximately ₹509 crore. Other lenders with REL exposure are watching the proceedings with



₹15.15 LAKH CRORE ALLEGED REVENUE MISREPRESENTATION FY21–FY25	₹12,726 CRORE ESTIMATED SHAREHOLDER WEALTH EROSION	10.8% LIC STAKE — BACKED BY CRORES OF POLICYHOLDERS
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understandable anxiety.

The reputational damage to Indian capital markets may extend further. Foreign portfolio investors held 17.7% of REL as recently as March 2023; that has dropped to 14.2% in March 2026. The message this episode sends to global investors — that a company listed on India's premier exchanges, audited by professional firms, and covered by analysts could allegedly operate an information black box at this scale — is one India's regulators will need to work hard to counter.

There are also international dimensions. Valcambi is a globally respected Swiss refinery. If the allegations are ultimately proven, the governance questions that arise at one of the world's largest gold refining operations will reverberate across global commodity markets.

WHAT MUST BE DONE NOW — FIVE GOVERNANCE REFORMS

The fresh forensic audit ordered by SEBI must proceed without obstruction, with investigators granted unrestricted access to ERP systems, primary accounting records, and party-level transaction data across all subsidiaries. REL's invocation of Swiss data protection laws must not be permitted to delay

THE
ALLEGED FRAUD, IF
PROVEN, WAS NOT HIDDEN
IN THE SHADOWS. IT SAT IN
ANNUAL REPORTS,
audited accounts
AND STOCK EXCHANGE FILINGS —
RAISING THE UNCOMFORTABLE
QUESTION OF WHETHER THE
SYSTEM WAS LOOKING,
BUT NOT SEEING

proceedings further. SEBI has already established the legal principle: foreign confidentiality provisions cannot override Indian statutory disclosure obligations.

A QUESTION OF SYSTEMIC TRUST

The Rajesh Exports case is not, ultimately, just the story of one company or one promoter. It is the story of a system that looked but did not see — or perhaps, in some quarters, chose not to look closely enough. Annual reports were filed. Accounts were audited by BSD & Co. and signed off. Disclosures were regularly made

Key RED FLAGS cited by SEBI

- ❖ Trade receivables outstanding for over two years — the original trigger for the March 2024 complaint
- ❖ REL recorded sales and purchases exceeding ₹11,000 crore with Affluence Shares and Stocks Pvt Ltd — a firm that denied REL was ever its client
- ❖ Corporate funds allegedly routed through promoter Rajesh Mehta's personal bank accounts; the company later admitted this occurred 'without revealing the bank account from which the funds had come'
- ❖ ₹1,035 crore investment in African gold mining assets with no adequate documentation of existence, ownership, or valuation provided to investigators
- ❖ Derivative trading allegedly conducted through the promoter's personal trading account, with related entries appearing in company records
- ❖ Repeated denial of access to ERP systems and primary accounting records by forensic auditors
- ❖ Invocation of Swiss data protection laws to withhold overseas subsidiary records — a defence SEBI rejected outright

to stock exchanges. Analysts published research. And yet, if SEBI's preliminary findings hold, a misrepresentation of truly extraordinary scale allegedly persisted for years.

The parallels to the Satyam scandal of 2009 are uncomfortable and unavoidable. In that case too, the fraud sat in plain sight in audited accounts — until it didn't. What Satyam did for IT sector governance scrutiny, the Rajesh Exports case may do for listed companies with complex cross-border commodity trading structures.

SEBI's findings remain preliminary and interim. Rajesh Mehta and REL will have the full opportunity to present their defence — and the company has maintained that the discrepancy cited by SEBI reflects a misreading of Valcambi's EBITDA rather than its revenue. That defence will be tested rigorously in the proceedings ahead.

But regardless of how the legal case concludes, this episode has already raised a question that India's regulators, auditors, institutional investors, and policymakers must answer honestly and urgently: How robust is the system that is supposed to guarantee the integrity of what Indian investors are told? The answer, this case powerfully suggests, demands immediate and serious reform.

1	Mandatory subsidiary-level quarterly disclosures	Listed companies deriving over 50% revenues from overseas subsidiaries must file subsidiary-level financials every quarter — not just in annual consolidated accounts.
2	Auditor access certification	Statutory auditors must certify, under penalty, that they have verified underlying transaction data at subsidiary level — not just holding-company ledgers.
3	Automated receivables alerts	SEBI and stock exchanges must implement system-level triggers when trade receivables remain unpaid beyond 180 days, requiring immediate public disclosure.
4	Promoter account segregation with criminal liability	RBI and SEBI must jointly ban routing of corporate funds through promoter personal accounts under any circumstances, with criminal liability for violations.
5	Independent review of LIC investment governance	Parliament and IRDAI should examine why LIC quintupled its stake in a company that every professional fund manager avoided. LIC's decisions must be demonstrably independent of political influence.

Return of the Pajero

THE REAL KING OF THE SUV WORLD IS STIRRING AGAIN FOR A RETURN TO INDIA, REMINDING A TOUCHSCREEN-MAD WORLD WHAT SCREW-THE-MAPS OFF-ROADING IS TRULY MEANT TO BE



AUTHOR



RAJEEV NARAYAN

There was a time when young boys pinned posters of sports cars on their bedroom walls. Then there was the Mitsubishi Pajero. This beast was different. It was not fast in the conventional sense. It was not glamorous either. Nor did it promise corner-carving thrills or Nürburgring lap records. It just provided something far more intoxicating. An escape. A generation of boys grew up believing that if civilisation ended tomorrow, the Pajero would probably keep running until the next one began. Long before 'SUV' became a marketing department's new best friend, the Pajero was already real. It earned its reputation not in TV commercials or social media videos, but in the unforgiving sands of the Dakar Rally, the world's toughest motorsport event. Between 1985 and 2007, the Pajero won the rally 12 times, a record unmatched in Dakar history. This catapulted Mitsubishi from 'manufacturer' to 'legend' status among off-road enthusiasts. Now, after years in exile, the icon is returning. And not a moment too soon.

SOFT-ROADER AGE

The irony is so caustic that India is already coughing on the exhaust fumes. For today's world is buying SUVs like there's no tomorrow. Yet, true SUVs have never been rarer. Roads are now overflowing with vehicles wearing rugged body cladding, faux skid plates and names that educe mountains, deserts and jungles. Most of these vehicles would struggle to survive a real encounter with any of these natural obstacles, for they are SUVs in the same way a treadmill is an expedition. Over the last few years, the auto industry has moved towards monocoque construction, electronic intervention and urban comfort. The result has been machines that are more refined, efficient and technologically advanced. But they are also less adventurous.

That brings us to the old Pajero, which belonged to a different era. An era when its appeal lay in what it lacked. There were no touchscreens, giant or small, demanding software updates. No elaborate drive modes with names sounding like Botox-fed retreats. No electronic nannies reminding drivers that a machine knows best. All that the Pajero offered was mechanical honesty.

It sported a robust diesel engine, low-end torque and a rugged four-wheel-drive system that enabled it to tackle terrain that most modern crossovers would avoid even in PowerPoint presentations. Owners routinely drove them for hundreds of thousands of kilometres. Even today, well-preserved Pajeros command extraordinary affection and price in the used-car market.

In a country where vehicles are judged by features, the Pajero was judged by stories. And stories age far better than gadgets.

BACK TO BASICS

The heartening part of Mitsubishi's revival plan is that it seems to understand what made the Pajero special. The fifth-generation Pajero, expected to make its global debut later this year, will return to a ladder-frame architecture derived from the Mitsubishi Triton. It will feature the automaker's proven four-wheel-drive systems and a twin-turbo 2.4-litre diesel engine, with hybrid variants following soon.

Thankfully, Mitsubishi is also positioning the new Pajero as a genuine



4th



3rd



2nd



1st

cross-country SUV, not another premium family vehicle. That matters. It truly matters. A ladder-frame chassis may appear to be an archaic concept in an age of EVs and autonomous driving. But for serious off-roaders, it remains the gold standard. It offers durability, towing capability and terrain-crunching toughness that monocoque alternatives can never hope to match.

In short, Mitsubishi is betting that authenticity still has a market. That alone is a refreshing wager.

FORTUNER KINGDOM

When the Pajero returns, it will enter a jungle dominated by a single lion. The Toyota Fortuner. For decades, the Fortuner has enjoyed a glorious run in the premium SUV space. Its combination of reliability, resale value, ruggedness and road presence has allowed Toyota to command prices that would have been absurd a generation ago.

At the top end, a Fortuner nears Rs 60 lakh on-road, despite offering fewer features than its cheaper rivals. Yet,

buyers line up. This is both impressive and tragic. Impressive because Toyota has built an extraordinarily powerful brand. Tragic because Indian consumers have next to no choice if they want a proper body-on-frame SUV.

The MG Majestor, a Ford Everest-based Endeavour avatar and the Pajero will inject competition into a one-horse race. Competition, after all, benefits everyone except monopolies.

REAL MACHINES

The Pajero's return has meaning beyond one model or company. It betrays a realization that buyers are becoming sceptical of excess complexity. As vehicles evolve into rolling computers, enthusiasts still crave machines that are tangible, mechanical and dependable. Sure, the future will belong to EVs and hybrids, connectivity and software. That transition is inevitable. But progress does not have to come at the cost of character. The best SUVs have always provided more than transportation. They have been a source of adventure, a symbol of

freedom, an expression of rebellion.

THAT IS WHY THE PAJERO MATTERS.

For India, the message is simple. The SUV market can support genuine choice, if given one. Consumers deserve alternatives. Regulators and automakers should encourage technologies that cut emissions while preserving the durability and longevity that made the Pajero a legend. Scrappage policies, urban restrictions and environmental green are fine, but so is recognising that sustainability is not just about replacing vehicles – it is also about building machines that last for decades.

On its return, the Pajero may not dominate sales. It may never match the volumes of crossover SUVs flooding urban roads. It does not have to. Its real mission is something else. To remind India that SUVs were something you took beyond the road, not timidly on it. If Mitsubishi gets Pajero 2026 right, a whole new generation may finally understand why the old one never stopped talking about it.

WELLNESS

THE SILENCE MEN CARRY



Men's Health Month is a reminder that emotional silence is not strength. For many Indian men, seeking help may be the bravest step toward survival

AUTHOR



ERA DUTTA

June is Men's Health Awareness Month. Somewhere in India today, a man is lying awake at night, irritable in ways he cannot explain, drinking more than he used to, carrying a heaviness he has quietly accepted as part of adulthood. He has not spoken about it. He may never speak about it. The possibility of seeking help may not even register as a realistic option.

This is not unusual. It is the norm.

From an early age, many boys are taught a simple but powerful script: don't cry, don't complain, handle it yourself. A good man provides, protects and perseveres. Strength becomes synonymous with emotional control, and emotional control is often mistaken for emotional absence.

These lessons are rarely delivered with malice. More often, they are passed down with love by fathers and grandfathers who inherited the same beliefs. In earlier generations, when life was marked by scarcity and instability, suppressing distress and continuing to function was often a survival skill. What once helped men endure hardship can become a liability when applied to emotional health.

The boy who learned at seven that tears were unacceptable may become the man at forty who lacks the language to describe his suffering. He does not identify himself as depressed, yet his family notices he has stopped laughing. His spouse senses his withdrawal. His children learn to interpret his silences. What appears to be strength may actually be emotional isolation.

The consequences of chronic emotional suppression are not theoretical. Here are some concerning facts:

- » Indian men die by suicide at nearly three times the rate of women.
- » Men are less likely to seek mental health support, more likely to present late with severe symptoms, and less likely to complete treatment once it begins.
- » When distress surfaces, it often takes indirect forms such as alcohol misuse, aggression, risk-taking behaviour or emotional withdrawal.
- » Depression in men frequently looks different from the stereotype many people imagine. Rather than sadness or tearfulness, it may manifest as irritability, persistent

frustration, physical complaints, emotional numbness and a gradual disengagement from life. » Often symptoms are dismissed as stress, burnout or simply getting older.

WHY DO SO MANY MEN AVOID THERAPY?

The common assumption is that men lack awareness. In reality, most urban Indian men know that therapy and psychiatric services exist. The barrier is often not knowledge but identity.

Seeking help requires acknowledging vulnerability, admitting that something is wrong and that support from another person may be necessary. For many men raised to view self-sufficiency as the cornerstone of masculinity, these admissions can feel threatening.

There is another obstacle: the absence of emotional vocabulary. Many men have never been taught to identify, name or communicate their inner experiences. It is difficult to seek help for a problem you cannot describe. Emotional exhaustion becomes "stress." Anxiety becomes "overthinking." Depression becomes "just tiredness." Psychological suffering becomes normalised as typical male behaviour.

PERHAPS the strongest thing a man can say is not "I'm fine", but "I need help"

Therapy, however, is not a confession of failure. It is a health intervention. Consulting a mental health professional is no different in principle from consulting a cardiologist for chest pain or an orthopaedic surgeon for a fracture. It is a structured, evidence-based process delivered by trained professionals and protected by confidentiality.

The man who seeks help is not weaker than the man who remains silent. He is demonstrating a more accurate understanding of strength. Real resilience is not the absence of struggle. It is the willingness to respond to struggle effectively.

Men's Health Month is a reminder that health extends beyond blood pressure readings and annual check-ups. Emotional wellbeing is not a luxury, but a fundamental component of overall health. The silence surrounding men's mental health is not protecting anyone. It is costing families, relationships and lives. Most of all, it is costing the men who continue to carry their burdens alone.

Perhaps the strongest thing a man can say is not, "I'm fine." Perhaps it is, "I need help."

One Drop of Humanity

Every unit of donated blood carries the power to save lives, making voluntary donation one of society's simplest yet most meaningful acts

AUTHOR



ANIL RAJPUT

Every year, World Blood Donor Day reminds us that the most powerful acts of care are often quiet, voluntary and anonymous. A person who donates blood may never know the patient who receives it. Yet, somewhere, that donation may help a mother during childbirth, a child living with thalassaemia, an accident victim, a cancer patient, a person undergoing surgery or someone facing a medical emergency. Blood donation is therefore not merely a clinical process. It is one of the simplest ways in which one human being can stand beside another at a moment of vulnerability.

World Blood Donor Day, observed on 14 June, carries special significance in 2026 through the campaign theme, "One Drop of Humanity. Give Blood. Save Lives." The theme places humanity and community care at the centre of every blood and plasma donation. It reminds us that one drop of blood is not just a biological substance. It is a symbol of solidarity, compassion and collective responsibility. In a world often divided by geography, identity, class and circumstance, blood donation carries a profound message. Human life is interconnected, and the health of one person can be protected by the generosity of another.

For India, this message is especially important. The country's annual blood requirement is estimated at around 14.6 million units, reflecting the scale of demand across emergency care, surgeries, childbirth, cancer treatment, blood disorders, trauma care and other medical needs. Safe blood cannot be manufactured in a factory. It can only come from healthy, willing and informed donors. This makes voluntary blood donation not just a health issue, but a social responsibility. A strong blood system depends on trust, regular participation and the confidence that donation is safe, screened and properly managed.

India has made significant progress in strengthening blood transfusion services, but the next phase must focus on regularity, awareness and access. Donation should not be seen only as a response to crisis, when families urgently search for blood during an emergency. It must become a planned civic habit. A healthy society is one where citizens



come forward before shortages arise, where young people understand their blood group, where institutions host responsible donation drives, and where voluntary donors are treated as partners in public health.

The encouraging development in India is that blood donation is increasingly being supported by digital systems. Platforms such as eRaktKosh are helping connect, digitise and streamline blood bank services across the country. Citizens can check blood availability, locate blood banks, find nearby donation camps and access important information through digital channels. Such systems are important because they reduce uncertainty during emergencies and make the blood donation ecosystem more transparent. When families can find reliable information quickly, and donors can connect with recognised blood centres more easily, technology becomes a bridge between compassion and timely care.

Digital innovation can also help India move from occasional donation to sustained donor engagement. In the coming years, donor reminders, appointment scheduling, blood group awareness, rare donor registries, stock monitoring, expiry alerts, barcode-based traceability and better coordination between hospitals and blood banks can strengthen the entire system. These innovations are not merely administrative improvements. They can directly affect lives by ensuring that the right blood or component reaches the right patient at the right time.

Another important area for India is awareness about blood components and plasma donation. Many people still think of blood donation only as whole blood donation. However, modern transfusion medicine often separates blood into components such as red cells, platelets and plasma, each serving

different medical needs. Platelets are critical for many cancer patients and dengue-related complications. Plasma has important clinical uses in bleeding disorders and other conditions. Public awareness must therefore expand from "donate blood" to "understand blood and plasma donation responsibly." This will help create a more informed donor base and support patients with diverse needs.

India can also learn from international experience without blindly copying any one model. In several countries, blood donation systems have become more donor-friendly through mobile applications, digital appointment booking and personalised donor engagement. The American Red Cross app, for instance, allows donors to manage appointments, view health information related to donation and even track the journey of their blood donation. The United Kingdom's NHS Give Blood app helps donors browse appointments and manage bookings. Singapore's national blood programme has focused on convenience, appointment-based systems and donor engagement, while Australia's Lifeblood model highlights blood, plasma and platelet donation as part of a broader culture of regular giving.

The lesson for India is clear. People are more likely to donate regularly when the process is simple, safe, respectful and transparent. A donor who has a positive experience is more likely to return. A young person

who receives accurate information early is more likely to become a lifelong donor. A workplace or college that organises well-planned donation drives can turn awareness into participation. A digital reminder after the eligible interval can convert a one-time donor into a regular contributor. A transparent system can build public trust.

At the same time, technology cannot replace the emotional and ethical foundation of blood donation. Apps, platforms and dashboards can improve access, but the decision to donate still arises from empathy. This is where awareness organisations, schools, colleges, workplaces, resident welfare associations, healthcare institutions and community leaders have an important role. The Illness to Wellness Foundation believes that wellness must be understood not only as personal health, but also as collective responsibility. A healthier India cannot be built only through hospitals and treatment.

It must also be built through prevention, preparedness, awareness and community participation.

World Blood Donor Day 2026 should therefore become more than a date on the health calendar. It should become a national reminder that safe blood is a shared resource and that every eligible person can help strengthen it. The "Drop Your Drop" idea, as a pledge-style movement, can be a useful way to turn intention into action. It can encourage citizens to know their blood group, register as voluntary donors, commit to regular donation, motivate friends and family, and support recognised blood donation drives.

For young India in particular, blood donation can become a powerful expression of citizenship. It requires no wealth, influence or position. It asks only for health, willingness and responsibility. A single donation may take a small amount of time, but its impact can last far beyond the donor's knowledge. In that sense, each donor becomes part of an invisible chain of care.

This World Blood Donor Day, the message must be simple but urgent. Let us not wait for a crisis to discover the value of blood. Let us build a culture where donation is voluntary, regular, safe and celebrated. Let every eligible citizen see blood donation as an act of humanity, and let every institution help make it easier to participate. One drop may appear small, but when it carries compassion, it can become a lifeline. Through awareness, innovation and shared responsibility, India can move closer to a future where no life is lost for want of timely and safe blood.

DIGITAL INNOVATION CAN HELP INDIA MOVE FROM occasional DONATION TO SUSTAINED DONOR ENGAGEMENT

Sita Beyond Submission

In *Sita's Veil*, Anamika reclaims Sita from centuries of simplification, presenting her as a thinker, rebel, nurturer and architect of her own destiny

AUTHOR



YAUVANIKA CHOPRA

If history is the paternal dadihaal, mythology is the maternal nanihaal. Both together lend richness to a civilization. In India, mythological history is inherited outside of museums; so domestic that gods and goddesses are our neighbours. "As any other common girl down the lane," writes Anamika in her Author's Note, "I, too, was born, connected to these gods and goddesses with some kind of umbilical cord. Parents and grandparents on both sides were people of Faith and it never struck me that Faith can be an apple of discord because I always saw both parents and grandparents deeply connected to people of other Faiths... all Faiths are close cousins who add colour and spice to the leela called life: 'khelet mein ko kako gausaiya' (in the playfield, who is the boss). Only when I grew up to the harsher realities of life, I discovered that both Faith and Marxism, which had begun their journey with the same kind of altruistic motives (the ideal of ego dissolution and also of granting self-interest a backseat) have ended up being victims of the same kind of non-dialogic oneupmanship and holier-than-thou approach."

Anamika is from Mithila - the land of Sita - and her father, Professor SNP Kishore, had been working on a Mahakavya about Sita when he passed away. His daughter took on the project as tarpan to her mother, an ode to her parents. This profound personal connection is a canopy under the larger sky of Anamika's book, which seeks to revisit and upturn our strange contemporary misreading of Sita as meek or passive. Anamika argues that Sita, Savitri, Parvati, and Saraswati were inherently independent. To flatten their strength is a disservice to them, and to assume that they were compliant because they were equanimous is incorrect. There are no silent, suffering women in our mythological history. The integrated feminism of the Hindu tradition includes Devis of all kinds, extraordinary and ordinary, and men are invaluable within its principles of equality in larger society. "Igniting the 'Dheerodatta', 'Dheerlali', 'Dheerprashant' elements even in the wildest of men is the objective of this Maithili or Tirhutiyia variety of protest which I refer to in my novel."

The title *Trin Dhari Ote* is taken from a verse in the *Ramcharitmanas* by Tulsidas: "Trin dhari ote kahat Vaidehi/ Sumiri Awadhpati Param Sanehi" (Thus spake Sita, raising the screen of a grass blade and remembering her dear Lord of Awadh). At no point during her captivity in Lanka did Sita speak to Ravan without the screen of a blade of grass between them. The Translator's Note by Nishtha Gautam records that, "In Anamika and my understanding, it is Ravan who needs to be protected from Sita, who's both the nurturer and destroyer. This veil [of grass] also reminds Ravan of his station: he can keep Sita captive but cannot access her... Sita grows like grass, undermining the pride of monumental masculinity." To both author and translator, Sita's own ability to destroy Ravan is unquestioned; she does not do so because there is a larger cosmic design at play which is destined to unfurl in the final consequence of Ram causing the death of Ravan.

The story of the Ramayana is well-known, as is the tale of Sita. Daughter of the Earth, Ayonija is found by the plough of King Janaka and raised in his palace. But, in this reading, Maithili considers herself a founding

despite her attachments to worldly parents and contexts. This larger awareness of being an 'orphan' enables her to see herself without any limitations of caste categories, and with the capacity to adopt any ideals: "With devotion Brahmin, with bravery Kshatriya, with calculation Vaishya, and with service Shudra—this freedom to become anything is bestowed on only those not constricted by the station of birth." Sunayananandini's earthly mother encouraged her to excel in both words and weapons. Janaki's earthly father shared with her the philosophies of Saraswati, Lakshmi, and Kali who regulate three different phases of time. This charmed childhood in the Baal Kaand of Sitayan closes on Siya's first, unforgettable glimpse of the Blue Lotus prince whom she knows she is destined to marry — Ram.

Ayodhya Kaand opens with their wedding: a day when ants and stars alike are asked to be elated together, and all the world seems to align in celebration of an auspicious union. Barely have the new couple settled into the heart of their kingdom when they are sentenced to a cruel exile. Sita's quest to accompany Ram to the forest is contrasted against the separation of Lakshman and Urmila at this juncture. But, having persuaded her case and arranged for the maintenance of her duties in the palace, Raghavpriya departs with husband and brother-in-law for a new chapter of her life in the Aranya Kaand.

Anamika's text imbues Sita with the virtues of patience and forbearance which have long been associated with her. As a forest bride on the banks of the Saryu,

Vandevi learns lessons from the daily conversation of village women and listens with restraint to disagreeable opinions from those elder to her. Yet she too is flawed, and her tendency towards overflowing compassion is

chastised by her husband; her pleasure in beauty becomes a source of sorrow when she coaxes Ram to capture a golden fawn which has delighted her senses. Thus, by a vice which is also part of fated destiny, Ratnagupta is taken into the Sundar Kaand.

"When gold is pure, it sparkles in fire." Hanuman's tail is set alight, but the blaze serves only to destroy Ravan's kingdom. Lanka Kaand is a short chapter for Sita, of war misses from a squirrel whose back is marked in the stripes of Ram's affection. News of her husband's victory over Ravan has only just reached, Seete has scarcely alighted from a chariot with an escort of Rakshashis to set her yearning eyes on Ram, when their long-awaited reunion simmers into a public trial of purity. Pavitrarai calls upon the God of Fire for justice — gold cannot be destroyed by flame.

The Nishkriti Khand of redemption ends with Sita's decision to leave Ram's kingdom for Valmiki's hermitage, where she gives birth to twins in the company of divine femininities, sage wives, forest women, and her worldly mother Sunayana. Mother to Luv and Kush, Lokajanani creates new life outside royalty. If Volume I (Secret Correspondence) of her Sitayan establishes that philosophical motherhood can be greater than biological motherhood, Volume III (Uttarayan) suggests that all dualities contain the potential for transcendence. "However luxurious a palace is, grass eventually covers it..." Having written final letters to Ram, Shoorpankha, and her two beloved sons, Bhoomija — daughter of Mandodari and Matangi and the Earth — returns to the infinite womb of her mother. Mahalakshmi's myriad mythological aspects continue to add colour in the leela of our lives. The lesson of Sita's life, in this novel and elsewhere, is of humbly radical faith that the cosmos in its own time-space will ensure its own harmonies.





Cricket's New Faultlines

AUTHOR



S KANNAN

BEN STOKES' CONTROVERSY, THE RISE OF WOMEN'S CRICKET, T20'S OLYMPIC FUTURE AND INDIA'S LEADERSHIP TRANSITION UNDERLINE A SPORT BEING RESHAPED ON AND OFF THE FIELD

These are tumultuous times for cricket around the world. For those who still insist the willow sport "is nothing" in comparison to the popularity of football, it is an exaggeration. Even as Colombian icon Shakira jived, gyrated and brought the FIFA World Cup alive with pulsating action in Mexico, chaos has been the order rather than the exception for this sporting extravaganza. If people still watch football and enjoy it, it is pure passion.

Away from the football turf, notably in England, the original home of cricket, there is a storm brewing — literally. Iconic captain Ben Stokes and Gus Atkinson getting into a scrap at a famous Chelsea bar last week with Saracens (rugby) player after the first Test win against the Kiwis has shaken the cricketing establishment. Lager and English cricket — it's a famous fusion. There is nothing cussed about 'downing' a few pints in England. Consuming beer in pubs and bars is a daily habit for many. The problem is when it gets noisy.

Just to jog the readers' memory, after a good win against New Zealand, celebrations involving Stokes and his teammates spilt over, literally. Had it been lager, maybe the noise would not have been so loud. Rum and Coke, and the ensuing brawl, have become a big issue for the ECB, the guardian of English cricket. Imagine England's historic Test venues have famous bars where men sporting jackets and ties sit and down a few pints as 'tradition'. Now, the same ECB feels order has to be restored, and discipline has to be enforced. Imagine, not just a night curfew (after midnight), but a possible total ban on alcohol in English cricket is being envisaged.

Is this England or a state like Gujarat, where prohibition has existed since the days of revered Mahatma Gandhi, one wonders. When did Englishmen begin to think that beer and booze were taboo, given their culture? These guys in the ECB must be kidding, trying to school professional cricketers who have been around for ages. Someone like Ben Stokes has played hard cricket for so long that he should be looked upon as an icon. That Stokes has been dropped for the second Test, along with his teammate, is bizarre. Imagine, for an incident considered bad behaviour, the ECB (England and Wales Cricket Board) boss turning into a moral science teacher. Alcohol has never been taboo in England. From the times of Ian Botham, who now says Test cricket is in peril, to the current generation, the consumption of beer is like tea in

India. The same goes for the Aussies as well.

There are various theories being floated. To imagine English cricket going 'dry' is hard to accept. After all, drinking culture has been ingrained there for decades. Ideally, rather than censuring players and giving interviews, the high priests of English cricket should have had a heart-to-heart chat with Ben Stokes. He has been a soldier for English cricket across formats.

Indeed, this year has been harsh for 'Big Ben'. Having suffered a major facial injury in February while coaching in Durham, he needed surgery. From there, he has bounced back. If, in this trying moment, he is going to be made to feel lousy, it's sad.

Frankly speaking, it does not matter whether the folks who run cricket are based in England or India. Old-timers in England feel their cricketers are having a whale of a time, getting to play for the country as well as enjoy their moments in the lavish Indian Premier League. Cricketers are entitled to such joy, as they have slogged for it. Not all make it big, so why behave churlishly towards them? Perhaps these men in the ECB also need to know how famous footballers representing the 'Three Lions' have dealt with the effects of booze. A certain Paul Gascoigne, better known as "Gazza", has battled alcoholism and madness on and off the field. Now 59, 'Gazza' admits that drinking for him is best done at home and not in noisy pubs. Nobody is saying drinking should be made fashionable, but if there has been an act of recklessness, dealing with it also calls for tact.

Please, do not bury the legend of Ben Stokes.

At the other end of the spectrum, the ICC Women's T20 World Cup has begun in England. India are competing in it, and the hype is justified. After winning the ICC ODI World Cup, there is optimism in the air that Harmanpreet Kaur and her bunch can do well. India have never won the World Cup in this format, though conditions in England will be challenging. The response to the blue-ribbon event has been heartening, with over two lakh tickets sold.

It goes to show that if an event is marketed well and has the right mix, there is demand for it. Then again, for those who will say football is bigger than cricket, avoid that comparison. Please.

Global cricket is changing. The landscape is not traditional Test cricket alone anymore. The evolution of white-ball cricket is defining the sport. From ODIs to the T20 format, instant cricket is a rage, not just in India but across the world. Accept that T20 cricket is here to stay and has now been accepted as a medal sport in the Olympic programme for the 2028 edition in Los Angeles.

India attaches great importance to every medal its athletes win, across disciplines. Cricket is being accorded top priority by the BCCI as well as the big bosses who run Indian sport, be it the Sports Ministry headed by Dr Mansukh Mandaviya or the Indian Olympic Association headed by Dr P.T. Usha. The Asian Games in Nagoya, Japan, this September-October will witness full men's and women's cricket teams competing for the gold medal. At the same time, planning has been intense since India will want to win the gold medal at the Los Angeles Olympics as well.

As written in this very column in the second week of the Indian Premier League, with an eye on the future, Shreyas Iyer has been rightly named India's T20 captain. There is nothing surprising about the elevation of Shreyas, the Mumbaier. He has been a big hit in the IPL across teams and ticks all the boxes. Transition in Indian cricket is now being planned. So, if you are realising only now that Suryakumar Yadav was being given a run only until the ICC T20 World Cup, where India emerged champions, accept it. Shreyas has been viewed as a potential leader for years. For timing his elevation perfectly, full credit goes to Ajit Agarkar, chairman of the selection committee.

Shreyas is a simpleton, the kind of bloke you can walk up to and have a quick chat with. He has been out of the Indian T20 team for over three years, but everyone knows why he deserves to be in the mix as a batter and leader. Importantly, Shreyas will be leading a side that will have a few seasoned players



GLOBAL CRICKET IS CHANGING. THE LANDSCAPE IS NOT TRADITIONAL TEST CRICKET ALONE ANYMORE

as well as youngsters waiting to burst onto the scene.

The T20 internationals planned in England and Ireland (subject to security clearance) could well see Shreyas leading with another youngster as his deputy, Tilak Varma. For those who are impatient, the arrival of Vaibhav Sooryavanshi, the teen star, is also exciting.

The 15-year-old kid from Bihar is aware that he is the cynosure of all eyes. It is good

that someone like captain Shreyas will keep him insulated. From the IPL to international cricket, it is a big transition. Vaibhav needs to be groomed for it.

If you thought Indian cricket's revolution is all about a change of guard and saying goodbye to the senior pros, hang on. Virat Kohli and Rohit Sharma, India's two solid ODI players, are still very much in the mix. There is some concern about their fitness levels. As committed cricketers who want to sign off next year at the ICC ODI World Cup in South Africa, the two former captains remain central to India's plans.

ODI cricket is much more demanding and intense compared to T20 matches. How Virat Kohli has preserved himself, everyone knows. If he is dealing with a hamstring issue after the highs and hard grind of the IPL, allow him time. He will come back stronger. Rohit Sharma has already received clearance from the Centre of Excellence (COE) in Bengaluru. All eyes will also be on ODI captain Shubman Gill. For Gill, more than form, the BCCI will monitor the highest fitness standards. His workload is massive, as he leads India in the Test format as well.



AISHWARYA, CANNES & BODY SHAMING

Bracketing showbiz women in stereotypes & other questions

From epitomising the stereotype to breaking it, right on the most glittering of global showbiz events, Aishwarya Rai Bachchan has sashayed down many a red carpet with poise and pizzazz

From epitomising the stereotype to breaking it, right on the most glittering of global showbiz events, Aishwarya Rai Bachchan has sashayed down many a red carpet with poise and pizzazz. Not the Peter Pan-esque beauty but one setting benchmarks for ageing gracefully - and happily.

She did so again in Cannes last month, becoming the centre of a furious debate on why women must be held to impossible standards, why they must conform to the expectation that they look the same year after year, notwithstanding the vagaries of life and time.

As Alia Bhatt and Aditi Rao Hydari, brand ambassadors for cosmetic giant 'L'Oreal', made their way



to the Cannes film festival this year, there was one oft-repeated question: where was the OG 'L'Oreal' girl Aishwarya Rai, a regular fixture at the movie gala for 24 years whose look is carefully dissected each year?

The 52-year-old model-actress, one of India's most well-known faces, made her appearance in a sculpted blue gown by Amit Aggarwal towards the end of the festival, her photographs and videos immediately flooding social media platforms. And the conversation once again turned to her weight. There was trolling and much body shaming.

Among those who spoke was journalist Mrinal Pande. "The natural beauty has diminished this time. The cheeks appear somewhat more puffed up," the Padma Shri-winning journalist known for her feminist writing said on 'X' and it soon spiralled into a huge debate.

When she was questioned, Pande defended her take-down, reasoning that celebrities are judged on a different metric. "Sorry, lady, she has been promoted the world over as an iconic beauty and a brand ambassador since 1994, when she won the beauty contest. Any dimming of that aura will be naturally pointed out using the same criteria the beauty pageant industry has set," she wrote. Some of her more critical posts were pulled out later.

Aishwarya has been subjected to trolling earlier. Unlike many of her contemporaries, the 'Devdas' star appeared comfortable with her post-pregnancy weight after the birth of her daughter



Aaradhya in 2011.

According to clinical psychologist Shweta Sharma, the criticism about Aishwarya's looks is more about the way society perceives beauty. "It happened before also when she gained weight after the delivery. Aishwarya has always existed in the minds of Indian women or I would say globally, as a beauty icon, as a Miss World, as a symbol of perfection. But the problem is that our idea of a beauty icon itself has become deeply cor-

rupted by rigid societal standards," Sharma told PTI.

"We admire her for her beauty, but at the same time, we never understand or we deny that they always have the right to age naturally. They can gain weight; they can change physically or simply look human, which she accepts as a celebrity, definitely with grace," she added.

Kangana Ranaut was the first from within the industry to school trolls targeting Aishwarya, telling them to get used to seeing older women on red carpets. "Fashion and style are self-expressions. It is one's own interpretation of life and their attitude. No woman owes anything to anyone. Ash looks great! Those of you who want to see her any other way, why don't you show what you've got? She is not here to please you. She is glorious. If you are not used to seeing older women on red carpets, get used to them now. Thanks," the 'Queen' star wrote on 'Instagram'.

Aishwarya's 'Devdas' co-star Madhuri Dixit said such trolling was sending a wrong message to society and especially young people. "Aishwarya has been going there for 20 years. She has done the whole country proud. She is a global star. As Miss World, she has done so much for the country. You cannot reduce her to a number on a scale or a size on the dress a size or a number on the calendar years. You cannot reduce her to that. She is beautiful. She looks beautiful, but she is beautiful inside," Madhuri told PTI.

"I think people have to realise that when you make these kinds of comments, what kind of message are you sending to the youngsters

today? That your worth is based on how you look, not on your achievements. I think this is a completely wrong message being sent," Madhuri added.

Aishwarya first appeared at the Cannes Film Festival in 2002 when 'Devdas' was shown at the festival. The following year, she became a brand ambassador for 'L'Oreal' and has been there since. She was also the first Indian actress to be on the festival jury.

Many Indians equate her appearance in Cannes as India's representation, regardless of whether there is an Indian film in the reckoning. In 2016, for instance, her choice of purple lipstick was the subject of intense debate. "Education is not going to help unless we are able to break that conditioning, which constantly tells women that their worth lies in maintaining a certain appearance and a body image. I feel this conversation is important because it shows how uncomfortable society still is with the natural relation of a woman's body and identity," Sharma said.

What is more concerning, she said, is when educated women participate in this criticism because it reflects how beauty norms are deeply internalised in social structures. Sharma further added that these unrealistic demands from women stars are diametrically opposite to how male stars are treated in the industry.

Sharma said men are accepted or allowed to age naturally and have the choice to play romantic and lead roles, but that grace is not extended to women in showbiz. "The conversation (when it comes to women) quickly shifts towards their appearance, their weight, their wrinkles or whether they still fit the image society created for them years ago. So that difference clearly reflects a gender-based double standard, which is very prominent in this industry," she said, adding that celebrities sometimes contribute to setting these rigid standards.

PTI

SENSE AND SENSIBILITY

Are the best things in life still free?

AUTHOR



BY SUPRIYA NEWAR

We come from a time when we heard, were taught and came to believe that the best things in life were free

We come from a time when we heard, were taught and came to believe that

the best things in life were free. From drawing rooms to classrooms, the material was considered junior to the felt. Joy could be found in gully cricket, a walk in the neighbourhood park, a conversation with a friend, a compliment unexpectedly received, a sunset by the sea or a sunrise in the mountains. The emphasis was less on possession and more on experience.

It was only much later, in corporate life, that I encountered a competing philosophy. 'There are no free lunches, I heard. The phrase carried a certain cynicism, suggesting that every apparent goodness concealed a calculation, every favour an expectation.

In all honesty, the world has not made it easy to defend the older proposition. Many of the pleasures that once felt effortless now come with caveats. Parks seem smaller, schedules fuller and stepping outdoors less inviting than it once was. In our crowded cities, even simple joys require a rethink.

So, does one abandon the old belief as a charming but obsolete relic? Or does one occasionally

stumble upon evidence that it may still be true?

Though I was not consciously looking for such evidence, a part of me continued to believe in it. It arrived unexpectedly during an aimless mobile scroll in the form of an old Hindi film song.

"Thande thande paani se nahana chahiye; gaane aaye ya na aaye gaana chahiye..."

My musical sensibility would assert that the song is hardly a masterpiece. The composition is pleasant enough, but nobody is likely to place it alongside the greats. Yet there is something wonderfully liberating about both the song and its picturisation. There is the hero, bare-bodied, 'lota' in hand, singing with complete abandon as he enjoys a simple bath. No designer bathroom. No imported shower fittings. No wellness consultant. No mindfulness app reminding him to be mindful. Just a man carrying out his daily routine and having an unexpectedly good time while doing so.

Bathroom singing may be one of the last surviving pleasures that is entirely indifferent to talent, status or validation. It does not care whether you are a trained vocalist or not. It requires no equipment, no subscriptions and no audience.



Many of the pleasures that once felt effortless now come with caveats

The curious thing is that while singing, something else happens. The mind, that tireless manager of

lists, deadlines, bills, errands and unfinished conversations, briefly loosens its grip. The running commentary slows down. For a few minutes, one is occupied not with planning the next hour or the next day but with entirely switching off the tabulations.

The songs themselves are an interesting study. Some people return unflinchingly to old favours

rites from their growing-up years. Others launch into current chartbusters that they may have picked up at the gym or from the radio. Some sing film songs, others break into 'bhajans'!

And then there is the curious question of language.

Much of modern urban life unfolds in English. Emails, presentations, meetings and increas-

ingly even conversations. Yet when people sing absent-mindedly in the bath, they often return to the languages in which they feel most comfortable.

In an age where so much of life is curated, measured and constantly optimised, bathroom singing remains gloriously resistant. It is private, purposeless and delightfully amateur.

Surely, bathroom singing is not the only best thing in life. There are certainly other contenders. But it serves as a useful reminder that the old saying still deserves a hearing. Not every joy comes with a bill attached. Not every pleasure requires planning, equipment, subscriptions or a destination.

Sometimes, sense lies in recognising that. And sensibility lies in making room for it. So be it bathroom singing or some version of it, each of us needs to discover our own version of that small, uncomplicated, uncurated joy that asks for nothing except participation and leaves us a little lighter, a little more refreshed.

Supriya Newar is a multi-lingual writer and poet from Calcutta. Besides being a music aficionado, she is also an avid traveller. She may be reached at connect@supriyanewar.com